

A TALE OF A THOUSAND SONGS BOOK INFO

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Characters From The Book; A Tale of A Thousand Songs;

Orcus & Iris (The Twins), Solis Patton, Esterica Kulio, Haruna Kulio, Mihel Kulio, Lady Emillea Hige, Queen Mihai Julie Patton, King Benjamin Lawrence Patton II of Aicruae, Ser Hert, Count Eserindeo Kulio (Mihel, Harnua, and Esterica's father), Alleria Amecken, Jaifey Yurea, Tixsei Yurea, Vinala Hinkina, Amiter Faserat, Xarcair Uetain, Rayelna Liqa, Exara Aedria, Olia Aedria, Kisaleli Jaeren, Pereino Demai, Reasaec Kivier, Kamerida Mava, Lynxan Mava, Rosolga Mava, Yera Haswengea of Pireaynea, Alizieya Aedria, Janileandora Aedria, Taryria der Vermer, Lasnstana Pontia, Jarani Renalagardo, Sevtor Orana, Mekanmena Orana, Tever Orana, Maeret Orana, Cequailian Orana, Mekan Orana, Heian Orana, Maen Patton, Coyre Patton, Snieoa Patton, Bier Patton, Elleinaj I Patton, Cenainaya Patton.

Character Name: Yera Haswengea of Pireaynea Role in story: Minor Character (Iris's "wife") Date of birth: Unknown (Pireaynean) Gender: Female Sexuality: Straight (coerced relationship with Iris) Age: Young adult during war Family: Unknown (enslaved) Backstory: A slave girl brought back from Pireaynea during Orcus's raids. Iris became obsessed with her because of her resemblance to Lady Emillea Hige (Solis's mother). Iris took Yera as her personal maid, tortured her, and eventually forced her into becoming her "wife." Although Iris claimed to love Yera, it was obsessive possession-Yera despised Iris and wanted to rip her skin off every time Iris touched her. Iris forced another slave who resembled herself to impregnate Yera, then killed him. Yera went into labor for three days; when she finally pushed the baby out, it was dead, and she was too exhausted to survive. Her death broke something in Iris and drove her to even greater cruelty. Physical description: Resembles Lady Emillea Hige Personality: Gentle, silenced, trapped Character inspiration: Gilly (GoT) + Shireen Baratheon (GoT) - gentleness under systemic abuse; tragedy as indictment of the regime

Character Name: Jaifey Yurea Role in story: Side Character / Kingmaker Date of birth: Unknown (Ghercian) Gender: Male Sexuality: Unknown Age: Adult during war Family: Daughter - Tixsei Yurea Backstory: A devout Ghercian military genius whose strategic knowledge surpassed even Solis's. He joined Solis's army with 60,000 Ghercian men and quickly became indispensable. Solis appointed him as general of the second army. Jaifey's ambition became apparent when he presented his daughter Tixsei as a potential lady-in-waiting to Esterica-a dynastic play to eventually produce an heir between Solis and Tixsei. He co-ran the Maeret Orana torture program and pushed for brutal reprisals. His plans were frustrated when Solis declared Maen as heir, blocking his dynastic gambit. After Esterica's death, Tixsei did become Solis's second queen-but their children (Snieoa and Bier) never inherited the throne. Personality: Cold, doctrinal, ruthless, ambitious Talent: Military strategy, logistics Character inspiration: Grand Moff Tarkin (Star Wars) + Tywin Lannister (GoT) - cold doctrine and logistics over sentiment; "ends justify" absolutist

Character Name: Tixsei Yurea Role in story: Minor Character → Second Empress Date of birth: Unknown (Ghercian) Gender: Female Sexuality: Straight Age: Young woman during war Family: Father - Jaifey Yurea; Children - Snieoa Patton, Bier Patton Backstory: Introduced as her father Jaifey's political gambit. Placed as Esterica's lady-in-waiting, she grew close to Solis during Esterica's forced absence and represented the threat in Esterica's nightmares. After Esterica's death by Harnua's poison, Tixsei became Solis's second queen-the political solution to a personal void. She gave him two children, but neither inherited the throne; Bier died of fever at 17, and Snieoa was passed over for Maen. Personality: Poised, calculated, patient Character inspiration: Anne Boleyn (The Tudors) + Shiv Roy (Succession) - poised ascent, agenda under etiquette

Character Name: Grand Sorcerer Sevtor of Vikistv Role in story: Minor Antagonist Date of birth: Unknown (Vikistv) Gender: Male Sexuality: Unknown Age: Adult Family: House Orana; Sons including Cequailian (betrothed to Iris) and Maeret Orana Backstory: The grand sorcerer of Vikistv and head of House Orana, the magical ruling family. He arrived in Aicruae with Duke Reasaec Kivier of Equateiy to avenge Iris (who was betrothed to his son Cequailian) and prop up Orcus. Sevtor unleashed a devastating magical strike on Valea that killed approximately 15,000 people-demonstrating the catastrophic potential of organized magic. This act radicalized Solis's coalition and legitimized brutal reprisals; his entire house

was subsequently burned alive except for one escapee (Mekean). Character inspiration: Saruman (LotR) + Vilgefortz (The Witcher) technomagical escalation, city-leveling intent.

Character Name: Duke Reasaec Kivier of Equateiy Role in story: Minor Antagonist Date of birth: Unknown (Equateiy) Gender: Male Sexuality: Unknown Age: Adult Backstory: The Duke of Equateiy who financed Orcus's war effort. He traveled to Aicruae personally with Grand Sorcerer Sevtor to aid Orcus after Iris's death. When the war turned against Orcus, Reasaec attempted to flee by ship. Solis personally attacked the fleeing vessel, captured him, and beheaded him. Solis sent the head to Gherci with a note written in Ananara: "The head of a rat-do as you please with it." The King of Gherci had the head preserved, mouth forced open, and hung at the castle entrance. Character inspiration: Lord Cutler Beckett (Pirates of the Caribbean) — financier-bureaucrat who outsources atrocity for order

Character Name: Princess Kamerida of Gherci Role in story: Minor Character (catalyst) Date of birth: Unknown (Gherci) Gender: Female Sexuality: Unknown Age: Adult Family: Daughter of the King of Gherci Backstory: A Ghercian princess sent as diplomatic envoy to discuss strategic plans with Solis. Iris and Harnua plotted to assassinate her to disrupt Solis's alliances. They attacked her ships, killing Kamerida and ten of her high-ranking ladies-in-waiting. Her death triggered the "Fight of Blood" and brought Gherci formally into the war on Solis's side-the exact opposite of what the twins intended. Character inspiration: Padmé Amidala (Star Wars) - diplomatic idealism that meets realpolitik steel

Character Name: Dame Kisaleti Jaeren Role in story: Minor Antagonist Date of birth: Unknown Gender: Female Sexuality: Unknown Age: Adult Family: Trained by Ser Wanez from age 2 Backstory: A fearsome warrior trained by Ser Wanez since the age of two, bred for war and absolute loyalty to Orcus. In the Fight of Titian (Chapter 62), she single-handedly fought Solis's entire first and second army, killing 700 men before the god Razar momentarily blinded her, allowing Solis to slip through and stab her in the chest. Her final words were "Glory to Orcus, the one true king." Solis slit her throat shortly after. Talent: Legendary combat abilities Character inspiration: The Mountain (GoT) + O-Ren Ishii (Kill Bill) - bred-for-war executioner; awe and horror in equal measure

Character Name: Ser Taryria der Vermer Role in story: Minor Character Date of birth: Unknown Gender: Unknown (likely male based on "Ser") Backstory: A knight loyal to Orcus who faced Solis during the final assault on the capital. When confronted, Taryria declared "I am no rat; do not think me such a fool-I will die defending my king." True to his word, they died fighting rather than surrendering. Character inspiration: Brienne of Tarth (GoT) + Maximus (Gladiator) - honor-first duelist; dies on principle, not spectacle

Character Name: Lady Olia Aedria Role in story: Minor Character Date of birth: Unknown Gender: Female Family: Mother - Dame Exara (Solis's second assistant general) Backstory: A noblewoman who sided with Orcus against her own mother, Dame Exara, who served as second assistant general of Solis's first army. Mother and daughter fought against each other during the final battle for the capital. Dame Exara killed her own daughter and refused to recover the body afterward, labeling her a traitor to the gods. Character inspiration: Yara Greyjoy (GoT) - duty-forward, will fight kin if the oath demands it

Character Name: Dame Exara Aedria Role in story: Minor Character Date of birth: Unknown Gender: Female Family: Daughter - Lady Olia Backstory: The second assistant general of Solis's first army. During the final battle for the capital, she faced her own daughter Lady Olia, who had sided with Orcus. Exara killed her daughter and famously declared "I am a terrible mother, for I shall wear my child's blood as victory and with honor." She refused to recover Lady Olia's body, labeling her a traitor. Character inspiration: Atia of the Julii (Rome) - ruthless parenthood where dynasty eclipses blood

Character Name: Ser Wanez Role in story: Background (off-page influence) Date of birth: Unknown Gender: Male Backstory: The trainer who raised Dame Kisaleli from age two, forging her into the legendary warrior she became. Represents the systems and institutions that shape children into weapons. Character inspiration: Ra's al Ghul (Batman Begins) - forger of weapons in human form; ethics subordinated to the "cause"

Character Name: Maeret Orana of Vikistv Role in story: Minor Character (victim) Date of birth: Unknown (Vikistv) Gender: Male Family: Father - Grand Sorcerer Sevtor; House Orana Backstory: The third son of Grand Sorcerer Sevtor of Vikistv. After Sevtor's devastating magical attack on Valea, Solis's forces kidnapped Maeret and experimented on him to discover the weakness of magic users.

Despite Maeret's repeated pleas for mercy, explaining he had no control over his father's actions, Solis ignored him and permitted further experiments. They eventually learned that fire is deadly to magic users because their cold-dependent bodies cannot handle high temperatures. Maeret was killed along with most of House Orana when Solis had their chambers set ablaze. Character inspiration: Stranger Things test subjects (Brenner's lab) — captive asset exploited for "science"

Character Name: Mekean Orana Role in story: Background (survivor) Date of birth: Unknown (Vikistv) Gender: Female Family: House Orana (all others killed) Backstory: The sole survivor of House Orana's extermination. When Solis had her entire family burned alive in their chambers, Mekean escaped by dying her hair and settling in Equateiy. She continued the Orana family line in exile—her descendants eventually include Merigen Bleelack, who becomes significant in later eras.

Character inspiration: Arya Stark (GoT) - reinvention, low profile, long game survivor

Character Name: Vinala Hinkina Role in story: Minor Character Date of birth: Unknown

Gender: Unknown Backstory: Co-general of Solis's second army alongside Jaifey Yurea. Died while securing Solis's escape route during an ambush in northern Aicruae (Year Four). Solis was forced to retreat without recovering Vinala's body. Upon returning to Valea, Solis slapped Mihel in front of the court for pushing him into the trap and banished Mihel until the mourning period ended.

Character Name: Maen Patton Role in story: Minor Character (heir) Date of birth: 7,217 BR (Year Four of the war) Gender: Male Family: Father - Solis Elias Patton; Mother - Esterica Kulio; Sister - Coyre Patton Backstory: Born during the fourth year of the civil war to Solis and Esterica. Iris threatened to kill him, forcing Esterica into hiding. Solis declared Maen his heir after receiving a prophetic dream from goddess Nimlye showing history repeating itself with sons fighting for the throne. Maen was 54 when he took the throne after Solis's death. He ruled for 23 years, renamed the empire "The Solisian Empire," but produced no heirs despite three wives. Upon his death in 7,140 BR, the throne passed to his sister Coyre's eldest son. Character inspiration: Tommen Baratheon (GoT) — soft-hearted heir weaponized by others' agendas

Character Name: Coyre Patton Role in story: Minor Character Date of birth: 7,215 BR (two years into Solis's rule) Gender: Female Family: Father - Solis Elias Patton; Mother - Esterica Kulio; Brother - Maen Patton Backstory: Born two years into Solis's rule, nicknamed "the light of the kingdom" for her beauty and embodiment of House Patton traits. Her mother Esterica died just six months after her birth, killed by Harnua's poison intended for Solis. Coyre later built a museum in honor of her mother, titling Esterica "Mother of a Dynasty." When her brother Maen died without heirs, Coyre's eldest son inherited the throne. Character inspiration: Grogu (The Mandalorian) emblem of renewal; everyone projects a future onto her

King Benjamin Lawrence Patton II Reign: Unknown — 7, 241 BR House: Patton (Royal Family) Family: Father of Orcus, Iris (by Queen Mihai Julie Patton), and Solis (by Lady Emillea Hige)

The last king of Aicruae before the civil war. Benjamin II's reign was marked by personal scandal and political instability that ultimately destroyed his kingdom. After taking Lady Emillea Hige as a concubine and fathering Solis, he openly favored his illegitimate son over his legitimate twins, Iris and Orcus. This favoritism drove Queen Mihai Julie Patton to madness (a combination of psychosis and schizophrenia) and eventual death.

At the Festival of Mourning in 7,241 BR, Benjamin II made the unprecedented decision to name nine-year-old Solis as his heir, officially disinheriting the twins. He died suddenly four months later under mysterious circumstances. Two weeks after his death, Iris and Orcus seized the throne and executed Lady Emillea, sparking the civil war that would consume Aicruae.

Benjamin II is remembered as a deeply flawed ruler—contemporaries called him "the drunken fool" behind his back. His court consisted largely of sycophants who stroked his ego while plotting their own advancement. His decision to favor Solis over the twins, while perhaps well-intentioned, created the succession crisis that led to the deaths of all three of his children and the transformation of Aicruae from kingdom to empire.

Queen Mihai Julie Patton (of House Vika) Reign: Unknown - c. 7,243 BR House: Vika (by

birth), Patton (by marriage) Family: Wife of King Benjamin II; Mother of Orcus and Iris; Daughter of Duke Rarielo Vika

The queen whose destruction became the emotional foundation for the civil war. Mihai Julie was the daughter of the powerful Duke Rarielo Vika, married to King Benjamin II as a political alliance to prevent House Vika from turning against the crown. For a time, she was renowned as the court's precious gem and the love of the king's life.

Everything changed when Benjamin took Lady Emillea Hige as a concubine. The public humiliation of watching her husband dote on another woman-and then watching that woman's son be elevated above her own children-drove Mihai into a mental break described as a combination of psychosis and schizophrenia. She attempted suicide after Solis's birth and was placed on medical supervision.

Mihai died during the twins' childhood, her death accelerating their psychological spiral. Both Iris and Orcus inherited her brown hair (unlike Solis's blonde), which became a visual reminder of their displacement. Their obsessive devotion to avenging their mother's humiliation drove the brutal atrocities of the civil war.

Lady Emillea Hige Dates: Unknown - 7,241 BR House: Hige Family: Concubine of King Benjamin II; Mother of Solis Elias Patton

The woman whose elevation destroyed a dynasty. Lady Emillea came from House Hige, a formerly fallen noble family. King Benjamin II brought her into the castle after having an affair with her, elevating her to the rank of concubine-only one level below the queen. She gave birth to Solis, whose striking blonde hair matched the king's own (unlike the brown-haired twins), cementing the king's favoritism.

Emillea was appointed regent for the young Solis after Benjamin named him heir. When the king died, the twins' coup targeted her specifically. During the takeover, Iris captured Emillea and her attendants. In a deliberate act of public humiliation, Iris poisoned Emillea in front of a crowd of onlookers, forcing them to laugh and

jest as she died. Nine-year-old Solis watched his mother's execution from beneath a floorboard.

Her death became the defining trauma of Solis's life and the moral justification for his eventual war.

Years later, Iris had Emillea's body preserved and stuffed, using it for sexual gratification while forcing Solis (disguised as "Jonathan Kiva" and serving as her guard) to watch. This desecration further radicalized Solis's hatred.

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[SOLIS ELIAS PATTON]

[The Great Usurper / The Golden King / The Godly Bastard]

Full Name: Solis Elias Patton

Book: A Tale of a Thousand Songs

Nicknames/Aliases: The Great Usurper, The Golden King, The Godly Bastard, Jonathan Kiva / Janrano Kiva (alias used during exile)

Birth: 7,250 BR, Second Month, 14th Day | Lajazer, Aicruae

Death: 7,163 BR | Aged 87 | Natural causes after 53-year reign

Age at Story Start: 16 (Chapter 5)

Book(s) Featured In: A Tale of a Thousand Songs

PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION

Ethnicity: White

Height/Build: 5'9"

Distinguishing Features: Blonde hair - same color as his late father, King Benjamin II. This is the first thing people notice about him, since his half-siblings have brown hair like their mother, Queen Mihai. Fair complexion with natural rosy undertone. Light stubble along jaw and chin. Pale blue-green/grey almond-shaped eyes with a direct, steady gaze. Thick dark brows contrasting with lighter hair.

Typical Attire: [To be filled]

How Others Describe Them: Recognized immediately by his golden hair; likened to the late king.

Scent: Frangipani - lush and rich; may smell like pineapple, plum, candy, ginger, coconut, or gardenias.

Zodiac Sign: Taurus

FAMILY & RELATIONSHIPS

Parents: King Benjamin Lawrence Patton II (Father), Lady Emillea Hige (Mother/Concubine)

Siblings: Prince Orcus Emere Patton (Half-Brother), Princess Iris Aleka Patton (Half-Sister)

Spouse(s)/Romantic Interests: Empress Esterica Kulio (first wife, died 7,214 BR); Tixsei Yurea (second wife, married ~4 years after Esterica's death)

Children: Prince Maen Patton (by Esterica, born 7,217 BR); Princess Coyre Patton (by Esterica, born 7,214 BR); Princess Snieoa Patton (by

Tixsei, born 7,209 BR); Prince Bier Patton (by Tixsei, 7,204-7,187 BR, died of fever at 17)
Key Relationships: Mihel Kulio (secret ally and brother-in-law), Harnua Kulio (enemy/sister-in-law), Razar the Sun God (divine patron - pledged a strand of hair in exchange for war tactics ability)

Step-Mother: Queen Mihai Julie Patton (daughter of House Vika)

BACKGROUND

Childhood: Third child and second son of King Benjamin II, born to a concubine. Adored by father, mother, and subjects. Father went against tradition and named him heir despite being third in line, which bastardized the twins' claim. The twins (Iris and Orcus) showed disdain toward him, though Solis adored them.

Formative Events: At age 9, two weeks after the king's death, the twins staged a coup. Solis hid under a floorboard and watched as Iris publicly poisoned his mother, Lady Emillea, forcing onlookers to laugh during the execution. He escaped due to his mother's sacrifice. Education/Training: Pledged to Razar (god of the sun), exchanging a strand of hair for war tactics ability. Spent years training as a mercenary under the alias "Jonathan Kiva."

Before the Story Begins: Spent approximately 20 years in exile building a mercenary army of 30,000 men. Returned to Aicruae at approximately age 29 seeking revenge and the throne.

PERSONALITY

Core Traits: Youthful, Mature | Shallow, Assertive

Greatest Fear: [Implied: becoming like those who hurt him - though he does]

Greatest Desire: To get revenge / rule the country better

Fatal Flaw: His pursuit of vengeance curdles into tyranny; he becomes what he set out to destroy

Secret They Keep: [To be filled based on story specifics]

What They Want vs What They Need: Wants revenge and absolute power.

Needs to break the cycle of violence his family created.

Personality Type: INTP

Unique Mannerisms: Holds eye contact when interacting

Likes: Politics, Winter, Dancing, Being with family

Dislikes: Reptiles, Witchcraft

BELIEFS & VALUES

Religious Affiliation: Pledged to Razar, God of the Sun

Political Stance: Believes in strong centralized rule; ultimately conquers all surrounding kingdoms to form an empire

Moral Code: Starts principled but deteriorates - sanctions torture, human experimentation, mass executions, and genocide of magic users by war's end

What They Would Kill For: His throne, his family's honor, revenge for his mother

What They Would Die For: [Initially his mother's memory; later, unclear - Solis survives everything]

ABILITIES & SKILLS

Magic (if applicable):

Division: N/A (non-magic user; later persecutes magic users)

Level: N/A

Specific Abilities: Received war tactics ability through divine pledge to Razar

Combat Skills: Exceptional swordsman and archer; personally killed 100+ of Orcus's men in a single engagement (Chapter 18); trained for 20 years as a mercenary

Other Talents: War Tactics (divinely enhanced), strategic military planning

Weaknesses: His rage blinds his moral compass; his trauma makes him ruthless

ARC & DEVELOPMENT

Where They Start: Gilded child adored by court (Ch. 1), shattered by the king's death and his mother's poisoning during the twins' coup (Ch. 4).

Key Turning Points: Pledges to Razar and reinvents as "Jonathan Kiva" (Ch. 5-8); marries Esterica and becomes "Golden King" (Ch. 25) - but embraces poison, starvation, and temple assault; sanctions torture/human experimentation on Maeret Orana (Ch. 56); burns House Orana alive (Ch. 57); duels Orcus and watches him choose suicide (Ch. 64).

Where They End: Consolidates rule, loses Esterica to Harnua's poison (Ch. 68), marries Tixsei, "cleanses" magic users across conquests (Ch. 69). Wins the world and becomes the cautionary tale. Dies at 87; son Maen renames the empire after

him.

Theme They Embody: Justice curdles into tyranny when vengeance is crowned.

ROLE IN STORY

Narrative Function: Main Character / Protagonist who becomes the villain whose conquest ushers in humanity's fall

Key Scenes: Birth celebration (Ch. 1); watching mother's execution at age 9 (Ch. 4); pledging to Razar (Ch. 5); killing 100+ men single-handedly (Ch. 18); marrying Esterica (Ch. 25); burning House

Orana (Ch. 57); throne room duel with Orcus (Ch. 64); burying Orcus beside Iris (Ch. 65)

Relationships That Drive Plot: Orcus (rival/brother), Iris (enemy/sister), Esterica (wife/conscience), Mihel (secret ally), Harnua (indirect nemesis) Impact on Other Characters: His existence and their father's favoritism destroys the twins; his war costs Mihel an eye and a leg; his conquest leads to Harnua's execution and Esterica's accidental death; his purge of magic users shapes the world for thousands of years

CHARACTER INSPIRATION

Real-World/Media Inspirations: Griffith (Berserk) - charisma, betrayal, ambition calcifying into something monstrous; Anakin Skywalker (Star Wars) - chosen one whose fall reshapes everything Archetype(s): The Chosen One Who Falls; The Conqueror Voice/Tone When Writing Them: Teasing and edgy. Mostly terse. Mostly indirect. Speaks with grammatical correctness. Short sentences. Juvenile humor. Jokes while being friendly. Good understanding of what is funny.

QUOTES

Memorable Lines: [To be populated from Quote Bank entries]

NOTES

Saddest Memory: Watching his mother die from being poisoned when he was nine.

Happiest Memory: Playing in the snow with his mother and father as the nobles watched; everyone around him was happy.

Book Smart or Street Smart: Street Smart

Active or Reactive: Reactive

Character Songs: Whatever It Takes (Imagine Dragons), The World We Made (Ruelle), Legends Never Die (League of Legends), Game of Survival (Ruelle), Empires (Ruelle), Glitter and Gold (Barns Courtney), Born Alone Die Alone (Madalen Duke)

Unresolved Questions:

- Confirm alias spelling: "Jonathan Kiva" vs. "Janrano Kiva"

Connections to Track: Razar (divine patron), Mihel (secret alliance), House Orana (victims of his conquest), Harnua (indirect cause of Esterica's death)

Research Needed:

[ESTERICA KULIO]

[The White Deer]

BASIC INFORMATION

Full Name: Esterica Kulio
Book: A Tale of a Thousand Songs
Nicknames/Aliases: The White Deer
Birth: 7,248 BR, Eighth Month, 21st Day | [Location TBD]
Death: 7,214 BR | Poisoned - accidentally drank Harnua's Ilkai-laced cup intended for Solis; died six months after giving birth to Coyre
Age at Story Start: 14 (Chapter 5)
Book(s) Featured In: A Tale of a Thousand Songs

PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION

Ethnicity: White
Height/Build: 5'5"
Distinguishing Features: Light blonde softly tousled waves with loose face-framing strands. Large blue-grey eyes with long dark lashes and faint winged liner. Darker brows than her hair, straight with a gentle arch. Porcelain-fair skin with smooth finish and pronounced rosy cheeks. Small straight nose with a delicate tip. Full heart-shaped lips with glossy cherry-red gradient and crisp Cupid's bow.
Typical Attire: [To be filled]

How Others Describe Them: [To be filled]

Scent: Nutmeg - beautifully spicy, fragrant; rich, woody, spicy, and sweet.

Zodiac Sign: Aquarius

FAMILY & RELATIONSHIPS

Parents: Count Kulio (Father), Yeaevi (Mother - Fourth Wife of Count Kulio)

Siblings: Mihel Kulio (Half-Brother, son of first wife Mihela), Harnua Kulio (Half-Sister, daughter of first wife Mihela), Barinei (Sister, same mother)

Spouse(s)/Romantic Interests: Emperor Solis Elias Patton (husband) Children: Prince Maen Patton (born 7,217 BR), Princess Coyre Patton (born 7,214 BR)

Key Relationships: Mihel (closest sibling - exchanged letters frequently during her exile; bonded over politics), Harnua (half-sister - sent her dolls during exile; rivalry between their mothers created distance; Harnua ultimately causes her death), Solis (met at age 7; married during the war)

BACKGROUND

Childhood: Born as second daughter to Count Kulio and his fourth wife. Loved by three of four mothers. Caught the attention of young Prince Solis, which threatened Count Kulio's first wife, who believed Esterica was stealing something meant for her daughter Harnua. Formative Events: Sent away at age 6 to be raised by her cousin Ser Minsupt in the countryside - devastating to both Mihel and Harnua. This exile shaped her independence and resilience. Education/Training: Book smart; talent in agriculture and farming Before the Story Begins: Returns to the city approximately 21 years later, ready to do whatever it takes to put Solis back on the throne.

PERSONALITY

Core Traits: Alert, Dramatic, Cynical

Greatest Fear: [To be filled]

Greatest Desire: Make a difference

Fatal Flaw: Her competence cannot outmaneuver the rot at the heart of the power she helps build

Secret They Keep: [To be filled]

What They Want vs What They Need: Wants to make a difference and support

Solis's cause. Needs to recognize when the cause has become the problem.

Personality Type: ISTP

Likes: Sincerity, Roses, Flirting, Late Mornings/Sleeping in

Dislikes: Traveling, Being touched on the back

BELIEFS & VALUES

Religious Affiliation: [To be filled]

Political Stance: Supports Solis's claim to the throne; exercises soft power through social maneuvering

Moral Code: Pragmatic but principled - begins to flinch at Solis's atrocities by the war's end
What They Would Kill For: Her family's survival and Solis's cause

What They Would Die For: [Did not choose to die - was killed accidentally]

ABILITIES & SKILLS

Magic (if applicable):

Division: N/A

Level: N/A

Specific Abilities: N/A

Combat Skills: [Limited - her strength is strategic/political]

Other Talents: Agriculture/Farming (sets up new agricultural sites to feed Solis's army), soft-power political maneuvering (the handkerchief tea party Ch. 27, rumor strike on Harnua Ch. 35)

Weaknesses: [To be filled]

ARC & DEVELOPMENT

Where They Start: Bright noble who mirrors Solis's light (Ch. 3). Key Turning

Points: Infiltrates Solis's camp to prove loyalty, nearly getting killed (Ch. 11); reforms agriculture to sustain the army (Ch. 13); executes soft-power plays - handkerchief tea party (Ch. 27), rumor strike on Harnua (Ch. 35); marries Solis (Ch. 25); bears Maen (Ch. 43); loses a stillborn son (Ch. 59); watches Solis slide into atrocity and begins to fear him (Ch. 57, 59).

Where They End: Poisoned by Harnua shortly after birthing Coyre (Ch. 68). Her death is the moral bill the story refuses to waive. Theme They Embody:

Competence cannot outmaneuver rot at the heart of power.

ROLE IN STORY

Narrative Function: Main Love Interest / The Queen Who Becomes Solis's Conscience

Key Scenes: Meeting Solis as children (Ch. 3); infiltrating his camp (Ch. 11); the tea party confrontation with Harnua - "You haven't won yet" / "Your horse will get tired soon" (Ch. 27); marrying Solis (Ch. 25); giving birth to Maen during the war (Ch. 43); stillborn son (Ch. 59); accidental poisoning and death (Ch. 68)

Relationships That Drive Plot: Solis (husband - her death drives his final descent), Harnua (half-sister turned killer), Mihel (ally and beloved brother)

Impact on Other Characters: Her death is the catalyst for Solis's grief-fueled conquest and magic-user persecution; her agricultural work sustains the war effort; her political savvy helps Solis win allies

Real-World/Media Inspirations: Casca (Berserk) - the competent queen who bears the cost of the conqueror's ambition; Margaery Tyrell (GoT) - political savvy, social warfare, public grace

Archetype(s): The Strategist Queen Voice/Tone When Writing Them: Caring and enthusiastic. Mostly terse. Indirect. Speaks with grammatical correctness. Long-medium sentences. Dry humor. Mostly goes on tangents.

QUOTES

Memorable Lines: "You haven't won yet." (to Harnua, Ch. 27 tea party)

NOTES

Book Smart or Street Smart: Book Smart

Active or Reactive: Active

Character Songs: Dynasty (Miia), Where Do We Go From Here (Ruelle), Beautiful Creatures (Illenium), Live Like Legends (Ruelle), Breath of Life (Florence)

Note: Met Solis at age 7. First wife's jealousy over Esterica catching Solis's attention is what got her sent away - creating a 21-year separation before reunion.

Unresolved Questions:

Connections to Track: Harnua (killer), Mihel (brother/ally), Solis (husband), Tixsei Yurea (Solis's second wife after her death), Jaifey Yuera (circled Solis during the marriage)

Research Needed:

[ORCUS EMERE PATTON]

[The Unlawful]

BASIC INFORMATION

Full Name: Orcus Emere Patton

Book: A Tale of a Thousand Songs

Nicknames/Aliases: The Unlawful

Birth: 7,256 BR, Ninth Month, 15th Day | Lajazer, Aicruae

Death: 7,217 BR | Throne room of the royal castle of Aicruae |
Stabbed himself after losing a duel to Solis rather than accept
banishment. Buried beside Iris at Rewqo.

Age at Story Start: 22 (Chapter 5)

Book(s) Featured In: A Tale of a Thousand Songs

PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION

Ethnicity: White

Height/Build: 5'8"

Distinguishing Features: Long dark brown wavy hair, center-parted and
pushed back, falling past the ears. Pale blue-grey piercing, slightly
hooded eyes with hard focus under a furrowed brow. Very thick, dark,
straight brows - strong, severe frame. High cheekbones, straight
Roman nose, defined jawline. Short tidy stubble with connected
mustache and goatee outline. Fair skin with cool undertone, smooth
matte finish. Medium-full lips with well-defined Cupid's bow, set in
a firm line.

Typical Attire: [To be filled]

How Others Describe Them: His brown hair makes him look like his
mother, Queen Mihai.

Scent: Raspberry - a sweet fruity note with a strong rose facet.

Zodiac Sign: Cancer

FAMILY & RELATIONSHIPS

Parents: King Benjamin Lawrence Patton II (Father), Queen Mihai

Julie Patton (Mother, daughter of House Vika)

Siblings: Princess Iris Aleka Patton (Twin Sister - born same day),

Prince Solis Elias Patton (Half-Brother)

Spouse(s)/Romantic Interests: Harnua Kulio (lover - initially
rejected her, later became sexually and politically entangled; loved
her in return but was unable to fully commit); Sterile - produced no
children

Children: None (sterile)

Key Relationships: Iris (twin sister - the only person in the world
he can rely on after their mother's death; her death hollows him),
Mihel Kulio (childhood friend turned secret traitor), Harnua (saint

devoted to him)
Step-Mother: Lady Emillea Hige
BACKGROUND

Childhood: Born first in line as heir to the throne (despite being born minutes after Iris). A pure-bred noble with no reason to doubt his position - until his father took on a concubine. Lady Emillea gave birth to Solis with striking blonde hair like the king. His mother was driven to madness and death by the king's affair and favoritism. His father named Solis heir instead of him.

Formative Events: Mother's death from grief and humiliation. Father appointing Solis as heir shortly after. The coup at age 15, where he and Iris seized the throne and killed Lady Emillea.

Education/Training: [To be filled]

Before the Story Begins: Has ruled as king for approximately 7 years alongside Iris before Solis's return is announced.

PERSONALITY

Core Traits: Reverential, Teacherly | Obnoxious, Selfish. Usually calm and cold - seems dead inside. Logical and analytical, but once kind, turned cold by circumstances.

Greatest Fear: [Implied: permanent inferiority to Solis]

Greatest Desire: To see his mother again and hug her. Make the world pay.

Fatal Flaw: Envy weaponized becomes a self-fulfilling defeat; cruelty as proof of worth

Secret They Keep: [To be filled]

What They Want vs What They Need: Wants to hold power and prove he is not inferior to Solis. Needs to accept that his worth was never measured by his father's love.

Personality Type: ESFP

Unique Mannerisms: Blinks often - spaced-out blinks like he's deep in thought

Likes: Rain, Sculpting, Astrology

Dislikes: Writing letters

BELIEFS & VALUES

Religious Affiliation: [To be filled - warns Harnua against using divine power to kill mortals]

Political Stance: Believes throne is his by birthright; rules through brutality

Moral Code: "Cruelty proves worth; to be feared is to be loved" though he retains enough conscience to warn Harnua about divine consequences and to refuse to

let her kill Solis with her powers What They Would Kill For: His throne, his sister's safety What They Would Die For: Chose death over living in Solis's shadow "I

would rather join our sister than live in this wretched place"

Magic (if applicable):

Division: N/A

Level: N/A

Specific Abilities: N/A

Combat Skills: Competent duelist, though ultimately inferior to Solis in swordplay and archery

Other Talents: Astrology, Sculpting, Military logistics (invades neighboring countries for resources, orchestrates surprise naval attacks)

Weaknesses: His calculated mind breaks when Iris is threatened or disrespected; complete blockage toward love due to parents' troubled relationship

ARC & DEVELOPMENT

Where They Start: Senior twin overshadowed by Solis's talent and the court's gaze (Ch. 1-2).

Key Turning Points: Coup with Iris (Ch. 4); famine-driven invasion of neighboring country (Ch. 12); enslavement at Pireaynea (Ch. 20); mass beheading of his own generals (Ch. 21); treaty-breaking (Ch. 31); sexual and political dependency on Harnua (Ch. 33); public fissures with Iris (Ch. 52); Iris dies (Ch. 53) - guilt hollows him, court faith collapses (Ch. 54).

Where They End: Cornered by Solis in the throne room, confesses a life defined by inferiority and chooses suicide over lifelong humiliation (Ch. 64). Buried beside Iris at Rewqo. Theme They Embody: Envy weaponized becomes a self-fulfilling defeat.

ROLE IN STORY

Narrative Function: Primary Villain / Tragic Antagonist Key Scenes: Twins' coup (Ch. 4); ordering mass beheadings (Ch. 21); rejecting Harnua's confession then

later becoming entangled with her (Ch. 11, 33); surprise attack from Quather Sea (Ch. 13); Iris's death breaking him (Ch. 53); throne room duel and suicide (Ch. 64)
Relationships That Drive Plot: Solis (rival/brother - the comparison that defines and destroys him), Iris (twin - her death removes his last anchor), Harnua (lover/political tool), Mihel (childhood friend turned betrayer)
Impact on Other Characters: His coup creates Solis's origin trauma; his brutality drives the war's escalation; his death speech reveals the tragedy beneath the villainy; his sterility means the twin line ends with him

CHARACTER INSPIRATION

Real-World/Media Inspirations: Kylo Ren (Star Wars) - wounded masculinity performing power; Cersei Lannister (GoT) - "anyone who isn't us is an enemy" paranoia; Zuko (Avatar) if he never got his redemption

Archetype(s): The Envious King / The Fallen Prince
Voice/Tone When Writing Them: Informative and serious. Fluctuates between verbose and terse. Mostly direct. Speaks with grammatical correctness, mostly. Medium-short sentences. Mostly goes on tangents. Bad understanding of what is funny.

QUOTES

Memorable Lines: "You have always bested me, brother, with arrows and with swords, with hair and with status. I refuse to live in a world where I must be reminded time and time again of my failure, of my lack of skill. Brother do you know that Iris and I used to call you the godly bastard all while you clung on to our legs like a weak lamb you were never viscous you could never kill back then even when you won you would hand us your victories times have changed yet you still want me to be second to you I would rather join our sister than live in the wretched place." (Ch. 64, death speech)

NOTES

Saddest Memory: Witnessing his dad appoint Solis as heir shortly after the death of his mother, Queen Mihai.

Happiest Memory: "Getting rid of Solis" and becoming the king of Aicruae.

Book Smart or Street Smart: [Not specified - implied combination]

Active or Reactive: Active

Twins share the same birthday: 7,256 BR, Ninth Month, 15th Day (Orcus born

minutes after Iris)

Character Songs: Detention (Melanie Martinez), Play With Fire (Sam Tinnesz), Say Amen (Panic! At the Disco), Rival (Ruelle), I'll Be Good (Jaymes Young), Warriors (Imagine Dragons), Family Line (Conan Gray)

Unresolved Questions:

Connections to Track: Iris (twin), Solis (rival), Harnua (lover), Mihel (betrayer), Duke Reasaec Kivier of Equateiy (foreign backer)

[IRIS ALEKA PATTON]
[The Damned / The Lady of Sorrow / The Gem of the People's Eye]

BASIC INFORMATION

Full Name: Iris Aleka Patton
Book: A Tale of a Thousand Songs
Nicknames/Aliases: The Damned, The Lady of Sorrow, The Gem of the People's Eye
Birth: 7,256 BR, Ninth Month, 15th Day | Lajazer, Aicruae
Death: 7,218 BR | Battle of Rewqo | Captured alive by Solis, broke free, killed 15 men, then killed by Solis himself. Buried beneath a temple of Nellebrie.
Age at Story Start: 22 (Chapter 5)
Book(s) Featured In: A Tale of a Thousand Songs
PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION
Ethnicity: White
Height/Build: 5'6"
Distinguishing Features: Dark brown hair with warm auburn undertones; loose natural waves pushed back from the face. Cool blue-grey almond-shaped eyes with tight liner and defined lashes. Thick straight dark brows. Soft oval face; fair complexion with natural pink flush across cheeks and nose. Small straight nose with refined tip. Full well-defined lips in soft matte terracotta/rose tone.
Typical Attire: [To be filled]
How Others Describe Them: Her brown hair makes her look like the spitting image of her mother, Queen Mihai.
Scent: Gardenia Augusta - smells like coconut, summer, fruity-juicy fragrance with tangy notes, a hint of citrus.
Zodiac Sign: Virgo
FAMILY & RELATIONSHIPS

Parents: King Benjamin Lawrence Patton II (Father), Queen Mihai
Julie Patton (Mother, daughter of House Vika)

Siblings: Prince Orcus Emere Patton (Twin Brother - born same day), Prince Solis Elias Patton (Half-Brother)

Spouse(s)/Romantic Interests: Yera (enslaved girl from Pireaynea Iris "loves" her obsessively but the relationship is abusive; Iris cannot understand why Yera does not reciprocate because abuse is the only way Iris knows how to show love)

Children: Forces Yera to bear a child via another man (the child is technically Iris's "heir" in her mind)

Key Relationships: Orcus (twin - the only person she trusts), Yera (obsessive, abusive "love"), Solis (the enemy she created)

Step-Mother: Lady Emillea Hige

BACKGROUND

Childhood: The only princess of Aicruae, "the gem of the people's eye." Loved by father, mother, and brother. Believed the world belonged to her and people existed to please her. Everything she wanted, she got - until Solis's birth and her mother's death.

Formative Events: Overnight transformation from revered princess to forgotten gem, overshadowed by Solis and abandoned by everyone. Watched the concubine take her mother's position. Mother driven to madness and death. At age 15, seized the throne with Orcus; personally poisoned Lady Emillea in a public execution, forcing onlookers to laugh.

Education/Training: Street Smart; talent in knowledge of poison and herbs

Before the Story Begins: Has co-ruled with Orcus for approximately 7 years.

Known for cruelty and violence.

PERSONALITY

Core Traits: Fun-loving, Sophisticated | Crafty, Cruel. Seductive and angry, very violent, doesn't mind getting her hands dirty. Deep down, a wounded girl who doesn't know how to release her anger.

Greatest Fear: [Implied: being forgotten/powerless again]

Greatest Desire: Spread chaos. Protect her brother and their position from being taken again.

Fatal Flaw: Her greed and anger are ultimately the death of her; she learns

intimacy only as violence

Secret They Keep: [To be filled]

What They Want vs What They Need: Wants control and vengeance. Needs to learn that tenderness is not weakness.

Personality Type: ENFP

Unique Mannerisms: Chews on lips, especially when angry

Likes: Painting, Animals, Hunting, Alchemy, Alcohol

Dislikes: Sick people, Thunderstorms

BELIEFS & VALUES

Religious Affiliation: [To be filled]

Political Stance: Rules through spectacle violence and terror

Moral Code: "Control is love; tenderness is weakness." Will kill or torture without hesitation.

What They Would Kill For: Power, Orcus's safety, revenge

What They Would Die For: Refused to surrender even when alone - died fighting rather than submit

ABILITIES & SKILLS

Magic (if applicable):

Division: N/A

Level: N/A

Specific Abilities: N/A

Combat Skills: Self-appointed general; formidable fighter - killed 15 men during her final stand at Rewqo even after being captured.

Personally executes generals and prisoners.

Other Talents: Knowledge of Poison and Herbs, Painting, Alchemy

Weaknesses: Her rage makes her reckless; her cruelty alienates potential allies; she cannot process love without violence

ARC \& DEVELOPMENT

Where They Start: Precocious, status-obsessed sadist who humiliates and desecrates to feel powerful (Ch. 2, 8).

Key Turning Points: Self-appointed general with spectacle executions (Ch. 11-17); enslaves Yera and engineers her pregnancy (Ch. 20); Yera's death breaks something real in her (Ch. 42) but she channels it into theatrical cruelty - fake-Esterica decapitation (Ch. 44); co-assassinates Princess Kamerida (Ch. 51); public censure by Orcus (Ch. 52).

Where They End: Captured at Rewqo and killed during escape attempt (Ch. 53).
Buried by Solis beneath a temple of Nellebrie. He hates and grieves her.
Theme They Embody: When intimacy is learned as violence, grief becomes a weapon, not a cure.

ROLE IN STORY

Narrative Function: Primary Villain / Tragic Antagonist

Key Scenes: Bringing 4-year-old Solis a bear head (Ch. 2); poisoning Lady Emillea (Ch. 4); slitting a general's throat and hanging his head (Ch. 11); falling for Yera (Ch. 20); Yera's death (Ch. 42); fake-Esterica decapitation (Ch. 44); assassinating Princess Kamerida (Ch. 51); final stand at Rewqo (Ch. 53) Relationships That Drive Plot: Orcus (twin - their dynamic drives the antagonist side), Yera (obsessive love that reveals Iris's humanity), Solis (the brother she tried to destroy), Princess Kamerida (assassination triggers Gherci entering war for Solis) Impact on Other Characters: Her poisoning of Lady Emillea creates Solis's core trauma; her assassination of Princess Kamerida turns Gherci against Orcus; her death hollows Orcus and removes his last anchor; Yera's suffering at her hands is one of the story's darkest threads

CHARACTER INSPIRATION

Real-World/Media Inspirations: Cersei Lannister (GoT) - grief twisted into cruelty, spectacle power; Griffith (Berserk) - the way personal wounds justify monstrous choices; Azula (Avatar) - prodigy cruelty masking profound abandonment
Archetype(s): The Tyrant Queen / The Wounded Predator Voice/Tone When Writing Them: Unapologetic and teasing. Mostly verbose. Very direct.
Short/Medium sentences. Blunt. Satirical humor.

QUOTES

Memorable Lines: [To be populated - her poisoning of Lady Emillea while forcing laughter is iconic but needs exact dialogue]

NOTES

Saddest Memory: The death of her mother and watching the whole world turn against her mother so a concubine's child could be heir.

Happiest Memory: Poisoning Solis's mother and watching her die while people are forced to laugh.

Sexuality: Lesbian

Book Smart or Street Smart: Street Smart

Active or Reactive: Reactive

Twins share the same birthday: 7,256 BR, Ninth Month, 15th Day (Iris born minutes before Orcus)

Character Songs: Sweet Dreams Are Made of These (Eurythmics), So Cold (Ben Cocks), Secrets & Lies (Ruelle), Way Down We Go (KALEO), Until We Go Down (Ruelle), Everybody Wants to Rule the World (Tears for Fears), Villains Aren't Born They're Made (PEGGY)

Unresolved Questions:

- The Blue Tower imprisonment (Ch. 2) - what exactly happened after the bear head incident?

Connections to Track: Orcus (twin), Yera (victim/obsession), Solis (enemy/brother), Harnua (ally of convenience), Princess Kamerida (assassination victim)

Research Needed:

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[MIHEL KULIO]

[The Fallen]

BASIC INFORMATION

Full Name: Mihel Kulio
Book: A Tale of a Thousand Songs
Nicknames/Aliases: The Fallen
Birth: 7,259 BR, Fourth Month, 25th Day | [Location TBD]
Death: [Survives the war - alive at end of novel]
Age at Story Start: 25 (Chapter 5)
Book(s) Featured In: A Tale of a Thousand Songs

PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION

Ethnicity: Black

Height/Build: 6'0"

Distinguishing Features: Short tight curls with natural texture, slightly tousled low-maintenance shape. Deep brown almond-shaped eyes with steady unblinking gaze. Thick neatly groomed brows with subtle slit in one brow. High cheekbones, straight nose, defined jawline. Short boxed beard with connected mustache and goatee - clean lines, intentional. Deep warm-brown complexion with healthy satin finish. Full lips with relaxed confident set.

Typical Attire: [To be filled]

How Others Describe Them: [To be filled]

Scent: Black Currant - fresh, slightly floral, foresty vibe with an incomparable balance of sweetness and acidity.

Zodiac Sign: Gemini

Parents: Count Kulio (Father), Mihela (Mother - First Wife of Count Kulio)

Siblings: Harnua Kulio (Sister, same mother), Esterica Kulio (Half-Sister, daughter of fourth wife Yeaevi), Barinei (half-sister)

Spouse(s)/Romantic Interests: [To be filled]

Children: [To be filled]

Key Relationships: Esterica (beloved half-sister - exchanged letters during her exile; bonded over politics), Harnua (sister - loves her but opposes her actions), Orcus (childhood friend turned enemy), Solis (secret ally - meets on Mystic Isles to plan rebellion)

BACKGROUND

Childhood: Oldest son of Count Kulio and his first wife. Appears to be the perfect son and heir to House Kulio; never had to fight for anything.

Formative Events: Seeing Orcus change after his mother's death; watching the twins' coup devastate the kingdom. His sister Esterica being sent away at age 6 by his own mother (who feared Esterica was stealing Solis's attention from Harnua).

Education/Training: Book Smart; trained in martial arts; exceptional observation skills

Before the Story Begins: When Orcus and Iris seized the throne, Mihel began plotting revolution. Changed strategy after learning Solis was still alive - began playing both sides to bring Solis victory.

PERSONALITY

Core Traits: Steady, Sensitive | Dependent, Airy
Greatest Fear: [Implied: failing to protect his sisters]
Greatest Desire: Become a leader
Fatal Flaw: His double-agent role costs him physically and morally he crosses his own lines
Secret They Keep: Secret alliance with Solis while serving Orcus's court
What They Want vs What They Need: Wants to become a leader and protect his family. Needs to accept that he can't save everyone.
Personality Type: ENTP
Likes: Reading books to others, Cooking, Martial arts
Dislikes: Heat and humidity, Funerals, Awkward silences

BELIEFS & VALUES

Religious Affiliation: [To be filled]
Political Stance: Pragmatic loyalist to legitimate succession; supports Solis's claim through espionage
Moral Code: Pragmatic - "You must not wait for the snake to twist itself around your neck, you must cut it off while it is still sizing you up." Also: "There are always casualties in wars."
What They Would Kill For: His sisters' safety
What They Would Die For: The cause - though he prefers to survive and lead

ABILITIES & SKILLS

Magic (if applicable):
Division: N/A
Level: N/A
Specific Abilities: N/A
Combat Skills: Trained in martial arts; competent enough to survive the war despite severe injuries
Other Talents: Observation (primary talent), strategic planning, diplomacy (secures Gherci aid Ch. 36), logistics
Weaknesses: Loses an eye in Year One (Ch. 23) and a leg in Year Two (Ch. 28-34); forced to pivot from front-line combat to logistics and diplomacy
ARC \& DEVELOPMENT
Where They Start: Loyal friend and double agent (Ch. 6-8). Key Turning Points: Loses eye in Orcus's counter-attack (Ch. 23); loses leg (Ch. 28-34); cedes generalship and pivots to logistics and diplomacy; secures Gherci aid (Ch. 36); Harnua nearly kills him in his sickbed before Esterica/Solis intervene (Ch. 33); must witness Harnua's execution and Ester

ica's accidental death. Where They End: Survives the war. Becomes a leader as desired, but at immense physical and emotional cost - lost an eye, a leg, and both sisters.
Theme They Embody: The fixer who crosses his own lines.

ROLE IN STORY

Narrative Function: Key Side Character / The Double Agent / Strategic Mastermind

Key Scenes: Plotting rebellion after the coup (pre-story); playing both sides in Orcus's court (Ch. 6-8); meeting Solis on Mystic Isles to plan strategy; losing his eye (Ch. 23); losing his leg (Ch. 28-34); Harnua's assassination attempt on him (Ch. 33); securing

Gherci's alliance (Ch. 36); advising Solis through the final campaigns

Relationships That Drive Plot: Solis (secret ally - their alliance is the backbone of the rebellion), Orcus (former friend - Mihel's betrayal is a major blow), Esterica (beloved sister - her safety motivates his choices), Harnua (sister who tries to kill him)

Impact on Other Characters: His intelligence network enables Solis's victories; his double-agent work puts both sisters at risk; his pragmatic counsel shapes Solis's strategy

CHARACTER INSPIRATION

Real-World/Media Inspirations: Varys (GoT) - network-based power, loyalty to a cause over a person; Tyrion Lannister (GoT) - brain over brawn, navigating between factions

Archetype(s): The Spymaster / The Fixer

Voice/Tone When Writing Them: Quirky and informative. Mostly terse. Indirect.

Speaks with grammatical correctness. Medium-short sentences. Decent understanding of what is funny.

QUOTES

Memorable Lines: "You must not wait for the snake to twist itself around your neck, you must cut it off while it is still sizing you up, because when it is the snake's time to kill you, it will not hesitate."

"There are always casualties in wars."

NOTES

Book Smart or Street Smart: Book Smart

Active or Reactive: Active

Character Songs: Void (Lil Nas X), Paralyzed (NF), Fire Meets Fate (Ruelle), The Other Side (Ruelle), Crossfire (Stephen)

Count Kulio had four wives; Mihel is the first wife's son, Harnua is the first wife's daughter, Esterica is the fourth wife's daughter.

Unresolved Questions:

- What happens to Mihel after the war? Does he hold a political position in Solis's empire?

Connections to Track: Esterica (sister), Harnua (sister), Solis (ally), Orcus (former friend/enemy)

Research Needed:

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[HARNUA KULIO]
[The Great Tragedy]

BASIC INFORMATION

Full Name: Harnua Kulio
Book: A Tale of a Thousand Songs
Nicknames/Aliases: The Great Tragedy; Thirteenth and Final Saint
Birth: 7,251 BR, Eleventh Month, 19th Day | [Location TBD]
Death: 7,214 BR | Burned at the stake by Solis | Used dying breath to raise a second moon in Orcus's honor; her death created the thirteenth month Agarisono (40 days)
Age at Story Start: 17 (Chapter 5)
Book(s) Featured In: A Tale of a Thousand Songs

PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION

Ethnicity: [Implied: Warm medium complexion]
Height/Build: 5'5"
Distinguishing Features: Long dark brown-black hair with center part and natural texture with soft volume. Deep brown slightly almond-shaped eyes with crisp cat-eye liner and full defined lashes.

Thick dark neatly shaped brows with gentle arch. Balanced oval face with smooth forehead, high cheekbones, refined jawline. Warm medium complexion with luminous glass-skin finish. Straight nose bridge with delicate tip. Full pillowy lips in rosy mauve gloss with sharp Cupid's bow.

Typical Attire: [To be filled - likely religious vestments given her position as a saint]

How Others Describe Them: [To be filled]

Scent: Aldehyde (c-12mna / 2-Methylundecanal) - found naturally in kumquat peel oil; scent is orange, herbaceous, and ambergris-like; at high dilution, tastes a bit like nuts and honey.

Zodiac Sign: Aries

FAMILY & RELATIONSHIPS

Parents: Count Kulio (Father), Mihela (Mother - First Wife of Count Kulio)

Siblings: Mihel Kulio (Brother, same mother), Esterica Kulio

(Half-Sister, daughter of fourth wife Yeaevi), Barinei (half-sister)

Spouse(s)/Romantic Interests: Orcus Emere Patton (the love of her

life - fell for him at age 9; her mother wanted her married to Solis

instead; relationship evolved from unrequited devotion to

sexual/political entanglement during the war; loved him until death and beyond)

Children: None

Key Relationships: Orcus (lover - defines her entire arc), Mihel (brother - she tries to kill him Ch. 33), Esterica (half-sister accidentally kills her with poison meant for Solis), Nellebrie (goddess patron - grants saintly powers)

BACKGROUND

Childhood: First daughter of Count Kulio and his first wife. Set to get the best out of life. Fell in love with Orcus at age 9 - the "wrong brother," since her mother wanted her matched with Solis. Suppressed her feelings to avoid disappointing her mother.

Formative Events: Discovered at age 10 she was a saint, blessed by the goddess Nellebrie. This changed everything - forced into a life of worship and solitude with a chastity belt; could only see Orcus twice a year (his birthday and the anniversary of his mother's death). Her jealousy toward Esterica (who caught Solis's attention, which Harnua's mother wanted for her) drove Harnua's mother to send Esterica away.

Education/Training: Book Smart; advanced magical/saintly abilities; historical

knowledge

Before the Story Begins: Has been living as a saint for approximately 7 years, seeing Orcus only twice annually, when news of Solis's return threatens everything.

PERSONALITY

Core Traits: Mature, Individualistic | Misguided, Arrogant

Greatest Fear: [Implied: losing Orcus forever]

Greatest Desire: Find true love, to finally feel free

Fatal Flaw: Devotion untethered from ethics mutates into holy terror

- "If I sacrifice everything, I can save him"

Secret They Keep: Her willingness to use divine power for murder; her deal with Nellebrie

What They Want vs What They Need: Wants Orcus and freedom from her saintly obligations. Needs to understand that love does not justify destruction.

Personality Type: INFJ

Likes: Solar eclipses, People with manners, Naps
Dislikes: Festivals

BELIEFS & VALUES

Religious Affiliation: Saint of Nellebrie (Goddess of Disasters) - Thirteenth and Final Saint

Political Stance: Initially apolitical (constrained by saintly role); becomes politically radicalized through devotion to Orcus - murders Cidet officials (Ch. 26), co-plots assassination of Princess Kamerida (Ch. 51-52)

Moral Code: Starts compassionate - comforts young Orcus under a tree (Ch. 4). Evolves into "any act is justified if it protects Orcus." What They Would Kill For: Orcus - and does (Cidet officials, attempted fratricide of Mihel, ultimately kills Esterica trying to kill Solis)

What They Would Die For: Orcus - uses her dying breath to raise a moon in his honor

ABILITIES & SKILLS

Magic (if applicable):

Division: Sainly Powers (blessed by Nellebrie, Goddess of Disasters)

Level: Godly - human with divine abilities

Specific Abilities: Advanced magical abilities (specifics to be detailed); at death, raised a second moon (named after Orcus, bigger than Solis's moon, spins three times faster); her death created the thirteenth month Agarisono (40 days); made a deal with Nellebrie for power to kill Solis using Ilkai (god-killing herb)

Combat Skills: [Limited physical combat - power is divine/magical]

Other Talents: Historical Knowledge

Weaknesses: Her obsessive love blinds her judgment completely; her powers draw divine scrutiny

ARC & DEVELOPMENT

Where They Start: Compassionate saint who comforts a grieving boy (Orcus) under a tree (Ch. 4).

Key Turning Points: Confesses feelings to Orcus - rejected as "more like a little sister" (Ch. 11); offers to use powers to kill Solis Orcus forbids it (Ch. 11); murders Cidet officials for Orcus (Ch. 26); proposes marriage to Orcus (Ch. 27); plots fratricide against Mihel (Ch. 30); nearly kills Mihel in his sickbed before Esterica/Solis intervene (Ch. 33); sexual entanglement with Orcus

deepens obsession (Ch. 33); publicly defends Iris; co-plots assassination of Princess Kamerida (Ch. 51-52).

Where They End: Returns as the silent avenger after Orcus's death. Makes deal with Nellebrie for Ilkai (god-killing herb). Poisons a cup meant for Solis, but Esterica drinks it instead. Burned at the stake. Uses dying power to raise a second moon in Orcus's honor. Her death creates the thirteenth month and ends the line of Saints (Ch. 68). Theme They Embody: Devotion untethered from ethics mutates into holy terror. Saint to zealot.

ROLE IN STORY

Narrative Function: Minor Villain / Surprise Villain - starts as sympathetic figure, revealed as one of the story's most devastating agents of destruction

Key Scenes: Comforting young Orcus under a tree (Ch. 4); confession and rejection (Ch. 11); tea party confrontation with Esterica - "You haven't won yet" / "Your horse will get tired soon" (Ch. 27); attempting to kill Mihel (Ch. 33); co-plotting Kamerida's assassination (Ch. 51); poisoning Esterica accidentally (Ch. 68); death at the stake and moon creation (Ch. 68) Relationships That Drive Plot: Orcus (lover - everything she does is for him), Esterica (accidental victim - the

ultimate tragic irony), Mihel (brother she tries to kill), Nellebrie (divine patron who enables her final act)

Impact on Other Characters: Her accidental killing of Esterica is the catalyst for Solis's grief-fueled conquest and persecution of magic users; her death creates the thirteenth month and a second moon permanently altering the world's cosmology; her execution ends the line of Saints

CHARACTER INSPIRATION

Real-World/Media Inspirations: Melisandre (GoT) - religious devotion as justification for atrocity; Lady Macbeth - love and ambition fused into destruction

Archetype(s): The Zealot Saint / The Tragic Devotee

Voice/Tone When Writing Them: Smart and snarky. Terse. Indirect. Speaks with grammatical correctness.

Long-medium sentences.

QUOTES

Memorable Lines: "Your horse will get tired soon." (to Esterica, Ch. 27 tea party)

NOTES

Book Smart or Street Smart: Book Smart

Active or Reactive: Reactive

Character Songs: Love Made Me Crazy (Taylor Swift), Hurts Like Hell (Fleurie), Fallout (Unsecret & Neoni), Revolution (Unsecret), My Love Will Never Die (AG), Wicked Game (Daisy Gray), I Found (Amber Run) Saints' deaths creating calendar months is a worldbuilding rule Harnua's death specifically creates the thirteenth month Agarisono (40 days).

The second moon she creates is named after Orcus, is bigger than Solis's moon, and spins three times faster.

Solis's subsequent purge of magic users is a direct consequence of Harnua's actions.

Unresolved Questions:

- What exactly are the restrictions/rules of being a saint? (chastity belt, twice-yearly visits confirmed - what else?)
- What were the terms of her deal with Nellebrie?

Connections to Track: Orcus (lover), Esterica (victim), Mihel (brother), Nellebrie (divine patron), Solis (target/enemy), the Saints system (she is the thirteenth and final)

Research Needed:

TIMELINEERA 8: THE AICRUAN CIVIL WAR & SOLIS'S CONQUEST (~7,260 BR - 7,163 BR)

NOTE: These entries should be placed after whatever era currently ends the TIMELINE doc (likely ERA 7). The format matches the existing Event/Location/Key Figures/Significance structure.

1Synopsis: The Aicruan Civil War is the defining conflict of the pre-imperial age, triggered by a succession crisis within House Patton. King Benjamin II's affair with Lady Emillea Hige and his decision to name their son Solis as heir over his legitimate twins (Iris and Orcus) sets off a chain of events that reshapes the political map of the known world. The five-year war draws in all six kingdoms and ends with both twins dead, Solis on the throne, and the stage set for imperial conquest.

Event: Birth of Orcus and Iris Patton

Location: Lajazer, Aicruae

Key Figures: King Benjamin Lawrence Patton II, Queen Mihai Julie Patton

Significance: The twin children of King Benjamin II and Queen Mihai are born.

Orcus is born minutes after Iris but is designated first in line as heir. Their births mark the beginning of the royal generation that will tear Aicruae apart.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 1 (referenced)

Date: 7,256 BR, Ninth Month, 15th Day

Event: Birth of Solis Elias Patton

Location: Lajazer, Aicruae

Key Figures: King Benjamin II, Lady Emillea Hige, Prince Orcus, Princess Iris

Significance: The third child of King Benjamin II is born to his concubine Lady Emillea Hige. Solis has striking blonde hair like the king - unlike the brown-haired twins. The kingdom celebrates, but the twins begin losing favor at court. Rumors circulate about the twins' legitimacy.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 1

Date: 7, 250 BR, Second Month, 14th Day

Event: The Festival of Mourning - Solis Named Heir

Location: Lajazer, Aicruae

Key Figures: King Benjamin II, Prince Solis, Prince Orcus, Princess Iris, Lady Emillea Hige

Significance: King Benjamin II goes against tradition and names nine-year-old Solis as heir to the throne, effectively bastardizing the twins' claim. Lady Emillea is appointed regent. This decision is the direct catalyst for the coup that follows.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 4

Date: ~7,241 BR (Solis is 9)

Event: Death of King Benjamin II

Location: Lajazer, Aicruae

Key Figures: King Benjamin II

Significance: The king dies suddenly under mysterious circumstances, just four months after naming Solis heir at the Festival of Mourning. His death removes the last barrier between the twins and the throne.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 4

Date: 7,241 BR

Event: The Twins' Coup - Seizure of the Throne

Location: Lajazer, Aicruae (Royal Castle)

Key Figures: Orcus Emere Patton, Iris Aleka Patton, Solis Elias Patton, Lady Emillea Hige

Significance: Two weeks after the king's death, the fifteen-year-old twins stage a coup. Lady Emillea (Solis's mother and regent) is publicly poisoned by Iris while onlookers are forced to laugh. Nine-year-old Solis watches from beneath a floorboard and escapes due to his mother's sacrifice. This event becomes the defining trauma of Solis's life and the catalyst for the civil war.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 4

Date: 7,241 BR

Event: Solis Pledges to Razar, God of the Sun

Location: [TBD - possibly Mystic Isles]

Key Figures: Solis Elias Patton, Razar (God of the Sun)

Significance: During his exile, Solis makes a divine pledge to Razar, exchanging a strand of his hair for war tactics ability. He adopts the alias "Jonathan Kiva" and spends approximately 20 years building a mercenary army of 30,000 men.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 5

Date: ~7,234 BR (Solis is ~16)

Event: Solis Returns - Civil War Year One Begins

Location: Aicruae (multiple fronts)

Key Figures: Solis, Orcus, Iris, Mihel Kulio, Esterica Kulio, Harnua Kulio

Significance: Solis re-enters Aicruae with a 30,000 -man army and attacks the capital's food supply, triggering the five-year Aicruan Civil War. Key Year One events include: the Battle of Jasereiey (trench warfare over mineral mines), Gherci backing Solis financially, Equateiy backing Orcus through Duke Reasaec Kivier, Mihel losing his eye, the revolt in Pireaynea, and Iris enslaving Yera.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 10-21

Date: 7,221 BR

2loses his leg. Harnua proposes marriage to Orcus. The tea party confrontation between Esterica and Harnua takes place.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 22-29

Date: 7,220 BR

Event: Civil War Year Three - Attack on the Cidet

Location: The Cidet (Temple of the Gods), Aicruae

Key Figures: Solis, Orcus, Harnua, Gherci envoys

Significance: Solis attacks the Cidet (the great temple), a controversial move that turns the church officially against him. Orcus rescues Harnua from the temple. The Treaty of Deouilu is broken by Orcus. Gherci enters the war on Solis's side after witnessing the twins' escalating brutality.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 30-42

Date: 7,219 BR

Event: Civil War Year Four - Death of Iris at the Battle of Rewqo

Location: Rewqo (city outside Lajazer)

Key Figures: Iris Aleka Patton, Solis Elias Patton, Princess Kamerida Mava of

Gherci

Significance: Solis employs a poisoning strategy (contaminating agricultural fields) and a letter campaign. Princess Kamerida of Gherci is assassinated by Iris, cementing Gherci's alliance with Solis. Iris is deserted by her knights at Rewqo, fights alone, is captured alive by Solis, breaks free, kills 15 men, and is killed by Solis. He buries her beneath a temple of Nellebrie and prays she finds peace. The period following Kamerida's death is known as "The Fight of Blood."

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 43-53

Date: 7,218 BR

Event: Civil War Year Five - Death of Orcus, End of War Location: Lajazer (Royal Castle Throne Room), Valea, the Quather Sea Key Figures: Orcus Emere Patton, Solis Elias Patton, Grand Sorcerer Sevtor, House Orana, Duke Reasaec Kivier, Dame Kisaleli, Ser Taryria, Dame Exara

Significance: The bloodiest year. Prince Maen (Solis's heir by Esterica) is born. Grand Sorcerer Sevtor of House Orana attacks Valea with magic, killing 15,000- Solis retaliates by burning all of House Orana alive (only Mekean escapes). Duke Reasaec Kivier of Equateiy is beheaded at sea.

The Fight of Titian sees Dame Kisaleli defeated (blinded by Razar's intervention). Ser Taryria and Dame Exara make their final stands. Orcus is cornered in the throne room, duels Solis, and stabs himself rather than accept banishment. Solis buries Orcus beside Iris at Rewqo. The civil war ends.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 54-65

Date: 7,217 BR

Event: Solis Begins Conquest of Remaining Kingdoms

Location: All six kingdoms

Key Figures: Emperor Solis Elias Patton

Significance: With Aicruae secured, Solis turns outward and begins conquering the surrounding kingdoms, transforming Aicruae into an empire.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 66-70

Date: 7,216 BR

Event: Death of Empress Esterica / Execution of Harnua

Location: [TBD - likely Lajazer]

Key Figures: Esterica Kulio, Harnua Kulio, Solis Elias Patton, Nellebrie (Goddess)

Significance: Harnua, still grieving Orcus, makes a deal with the goddess Nellebrie and obtains Ilkai (a god-killing herb). She poisons a cup intended for Solis, but

Esterica accidentally drinks it and dies - six months after giving birth to Princess Coyre. Solis burns Harnua at the stake. With her dying breath, Harnua raises a second moon in Orcus's honor (bigger than Solis's moon, spins three times faster). Her death creates the thirteenth month, Agarisono (40 days), and ends the line of Saints. Grief-maddened, Solis launches a persecution of magic users across the realm.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 68

Date: 7,214BR

Event: Death of Emperor Solis

Location: [TBD]

Key Figures: Emperor Solis Elias Patton, Prince Maen Patton

Significance: Solis dies at age 87 after ruling for 53 years. His eldest son Maen (age 54) takes the throne and renames the empire the "Solisian Empire." Solis is remembered in history as the king of light and bringer of the new age - but the narrative frames him as the villain whose conquest ushered in humanity's fall.

Book Reference: A Tale of a Thousand Songs, Ch. 70 (epilogue)

Date: 7,163 BR

Event: Death of Emperor Maen / Succession

Location: [TBD]

Key Figures: Emperor Maen Patton, Princess Coyre Patton

Significance: Maen dies after ruling 23 years. He produced no heirs despite three wives. The throne passes to Princess Coyre's eldest son (Elleinaj I), beginning the next phase of the Solisian dynasty.

Book Reference: [Referenced in epilogue material]

Date: 7,140 BR

Pro-Solis:

- Gherci (after Princess Kamerida's assassination)
- House Kulio (secretly through Mihel)

Pro-Orcus/Iris:

- Equateiy (financing through Duke Reasaec Kivier)
- Vikistv (magical support through House Orana)
- Coelum (economically dependent on Equateiy/Vikistv)
- House Vika (initially - Queen Mihai's family)
- House Vemer

Neutral:

Pireaynea (contested, exploited by both sides)

A TALE OF A THOUSAND SONGS

CHAPTER-BY-CHAPTER STORY BIBLE

Last Updated: February 17, 2026
 70 Chapters | 7 Arcs | ~7,256 BR - 7,163 BR
 Genre: Historical Fantasy | YA/New Adult
 Theme: How parents turn siblings against one another;
 the cycle of revenge and the breaking of cycles
 Chapters 1-3: EXPANDED (full scene breakdowns, character
 descriptions at first appearance, key dialogue, and
 thematic analysis from chapter deep dives)
 Chapters 4-70: SUMMARY FORMAT (war year, key characters,
 locations, major plot beats)
 ARC I: THE GOLDEN CHILDHOOD
 Chapters 1-4 | ~7,250 BR - 7,241 BR | Pre-War

Focus: Solis's childhood, the fracturing of the royal family, the twins' growing resentment, and the coup that starts everything.

CHAPTER 1: THE GOLDEN-HAIRED PRINCE

| Period: | 7,250 BR, Second Month (Solis's birth) |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Lajazer - Royal Castle (Vawer Hall, Queen's Chambers, Lady Emillea's Chambers & Courtyard) |

| POV: | Prince Orcus Emere Patton (first person, retrospective narration) |

| Structure: | Three scenes |

SCENE ONE: SOLIS'S BIRTH

Location: Outside the birthing chamber, Vawer Hall

OPENING MONOLOGUE - ORCUS'S PHILOSOPHY:

The chapter opens with adult Orcus narrating retrospectively, establishing the tragic framing of the entire story. He questions House Patton's words ("Above Human, Below God"), references the founding prophecy of King Haliour Layern Patton I (the dream of two panthers fighting on a cliff, bleeding gold, after meeting Razar), and asks whether the founder foresaw brothers turning against brothers.

Orcus concludes the gods are responsible, and questions when the "cruel game of fate" truly began - with Solis's birth, or long before that. This retrospective voice confirms adult Orcus already knows the tragic ending as he narrates.

THE BIRTHING CHAMBER:

Orcus secretly watches from outside the room. Inside:

The Maids:

- An older palace maid - "vulture-like eyes"
- A younger maid - trembling, clumsy; spills water from a basin and drops to her knees in terror begging mercy
- Both drop knee-deep in water, bowing when the king enters

The King's Entrance:

King Benjamin arrives tipsy, unsteady on his feet, but his voice is "cold and commanding" - it "slices through the air." He responds to the spilled water with contempt, asking if there's a problem.

Named Servants in the Room:

FERIANA - pours the king's wine

PEGNI - cleans his chambers

Orcus notes: "Father hardly notices them - they're just shadows to him."

Orcus's thought: If he becomes king, are those the friends he'll have? If so, he'd rather keep it just him and Iris.

The Nobles:

A group of men "decorated in flashy metals of honor" dressed in "vibrant orange, green, and blue" (House Hige colors). They exchange "important politics" that Orcus sees as "drunken boasting and empty words." Half the room barely looks at the king, fearing what he'd do if defied.

Orcus's observation: If he weren't king, would they still fawn over him?

ORCUS ON POWER:

On being feared: His mother once told him people would bow before him the same way. He finds the idea unpleasant:

"Who would want to be friends with me if everyone fears me?"

This is young Orcus at his most human - he doesn't want to be feared. He wants friends.

LADY EMILLEA DURING BIRTH:

- "Her youthful face still radiant despite her pain"
- "Light brown hair flowed in gentle waves"
- Eyes "shimmered with the brilliance of rare sapphires and emeralds"
- She smiles at the king "as if desperate to hold onto hope"
- The king briefly kisses her forehead, moves her hair aside, then immediately returns to the men

THE MASKED PHYSICIAN:

A figure in a "flowy black robe with a brightly colored blue feathery mask" materializes "as if emerging from the shadows." Performs a ritual: pours dark liquid into a small glowing lamp that hisses, mutters low words, fills the room with lavender scent.

Smears contents from a bottle onto Solis's face - "the symbol for strength."

THE LAVENDER MEMORY:

Orcus recalls the only other time he smelled lavender: nobles from a back alleyway gave it to Queen Mihai as a cruel joke, and she burned it in the fireplace, making the twins watch. This lavender "smells different, calmer" - but anything done in his mother's presence is "never a calming thing."

Worldbuilding note: Lavender is Lady Emillea's signature scent (calm, pleasant). For the twins, lavender carries the memory of their mother's humiliation. Scent as emotional shorthand.

SOLIS'S BIRTH:

- Golden hair, blue eyes "that could be seen even from where I was"
- Extremely vocal - cries shatter the calm
- The king briefly shows the child to Emillea; she gazes with "soft eyes"
- Presentation: "All have borne witness to the birth of my son, Prince Solis Elias Patton of Aicruae; bow down before him and accept his status as Prince of this kingdom."
- The king is "smiling ear to ear like a lion"
- The nobles repeat "Long may he live in the grace of the gods!" heads touching the floor "like a spell has been placed upon them"
- Orcus's commentary: "the terrifying, undeniable power of a King. These poor men traveled weeks to get here, and when they're not kissing my Father's ass, their heads are touching the floor, dear gods. How ridiculous."

ORCUS'S HOPES FOR HIS BROTHER:

He's never had a brother before. His musings:

- If Solis is like Orcus: they could read books together
- If Solis is like Iris: he should learn archery to join them on journeys (foreshadows the Ch 2 archery failure)
- Watches baby Solis cry while Pegni runs in circles and

Feriana fidgets, trying to cover her ears

- Assessment: "This child is quite cute, but if he is as particular as Iris, perhaps learning about shooting arrows would be a good start."
- On the name: "A name like Solis does suit him, like a sun that sits atop the sky; he is a beautiful child."

ALLERIA'S ARRIVAL - THE NERAI REVELATION:

ALLERIA AMECKEN - FIRST APPEARANCE

Role: Queen Mihai's head maid (her ONLY maid)
Hair: Raven-like, currently tangled
Eyes: Slightly red (she's been crying)
Dress: Modest light purple (House Vika color)
Demeanor: Walks with purpose - Orcus recognizes her by her footsteps alone. Voice is timid and exhausted.
Character: Normally fearsome enough that when she disciplined the twins, she "wouldn't so much as flinch." Seeing her grovel before the king is shocking enough that Orcus would risk anything to witness it.

Alleria bursts in to report that Queen Mihai is drinking an elixir containing NERAI (the deadly poison from House Vika - "Joyless Death" - that targets the nervous system and kills almost instantly).

The king's response: "I do not care what has happened to that woman." When pressed: "If you have nothing useful to say, why waste our time with useless babble?"

Orcus notes this expression is the only one his father ever shows when his mother is mentioned - "and his expression has been that way since I was born."

The room fills with faint whispers from the nobles.

Orcus on the risk: If caught eavesdropping, his father would "likely hang me without a second thought."

SCENE TWO: QUEEN MIHAI'S CHAMBERS Location: The queen's wing - long, black-shrouded

|| corridor; her dimly lit chamber ||

THE CORRIDOR:

Described as "long, black-shrouded" - the black shrouding suggests House Patton's mourning colors or simple neglect/darkness.

THE QUEEN'S CHAMBER:

- Dimly lit by a single candlestick
- The smell of mold "consumes everything, including my mother's bed"

- Contrast with Emillea's chambers is total (see Scene 3)

QUEEN MIHAI JULIE PATTON - FIRST DETAILED DESCRIPTION

Hair: In disarray
 Clothing: Nightgown covered in sweat and vomit
 Eyes: "White overtaking the brown"
 Movements: Shaky
 Skin: Cold and brittle
 Bedding: One thin, putrid cover (despite being queen - total neglect)
 Chamber: Single candlestick, mold, decay
 Mental State: Active psychosis/schizophrenia breakdown; self-medicating with Nerai elixir
 Physical Behavior: Violent when triggered - grabs Iris hard enough to make her wince

IRIS'S PRESENCE:

Orcus finds Iris already in the chamber, caring for their mother.

IRIS ALEKA PATTON - FIRST PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION

Hair: Long, flowy dark brown; when tied neatly, she looks like their mother's twin
 Eyes: Dark blue (Patton family trait)
 Demeanor: "Although her eyes always seem to hold a certain fire, that characteristic spark was conspicuously absent at the moment." Their mother "always seems to dampen that fire, leaving only a flicker."
 Age: 5 years old
 Already sharp-tongued and proud
 Wearing: The amethyst necklace - a cherished

gift from their father (she grasps it when she overhears the betrothal plan later)

THE SIBLINGS' CONVERSATION:

Orcus asks where their father is. Iris: "How must I know brother, he is not here, that much is clear, probably with his shiny new toy." When Orcus warns her to be careful what she says, Iris declares herself "the only true princess of Aicruae" - above punishment even from "the wench and her bastard."

Orcus tells her about Solis's birth. He deflects by grabbing a large red book with gold framing: "The Art of the Bow." While flipping through it, his mind wanders back to baby Solis - the "little scoop of blonde hair" and how he squirmed in Emillea's arms. (This shows Orcus's tenderness even as he tries to hide it.)

Iris snatches the book and throws it under the bed, forcing him to answer. She lectures him about kingly behavior - reading is "meant for peasants." Orcus says "If I become king, sister" - the "if" alarms Iris, who insists a "bastard born of a whore" could never be king because it's "against the very order of things."

Orcus challenges: "No one knows the will of the gods, not even Father." Iris counters: "Father is a fool. He is not a vessel for the gods. You, however, are proof of divine order, brother."

QUEEN MIHAI AWAKENS:

She scans the room for the king. Hair disheveled, nightgown sweat-drenched, movements shaky, whites of eyes dominating the brown. When Iris lies about the king having "important work," Mihai grabs her arm and yanks her down to bed level, increasing her grip until Iris winces: "Do not lie to me. Is your father in the presence of the wench? Has her child been born?"

Orcus pulls their mother off Iris. Mihai slumps, crying, voice "muffled and ashamed."

THE QUEEN'S CONFESSION:

"My dear boy, you always take care of your mother. I have raised a good one, haven't I? And my dear daughter always stands beside her brother. I wish I had held your father more tightly. Your mother is sorry."

The siblings exchange a glance, embrace her tighter:

"We know, mother, we know."

She drifts back to sleep.

THE BOOM FROM VAWER HALL:

An unexplained loud sound startles the twins. They investigate and overhear a discussion about betrothing Iris to the third son of the King of Vikistv (this is Cequailian Orana, second oldest son of Grand Sorcerer Sevtor). Count Yainaro proposes it; the king praises him for "finally using the brain the gods have so graciously blessed you with."

IRIS'S TURNING POINT:

After overhearing the betrothal plan, Iris says while walking away, clutching her father's amethyst necklace: "He had one chance." She's already conflating Solis with her father's betrayal. The "one chance" she'd given Solis (at Orcus's pleading) is now revoked.

SCENE THREE: LADY EMILLEA'S TEA PARTY

| Location: Lady Emillea's chambers and courtyard

TIME SKIP:

One week after Solis's birth. Gifts have arrived from every country - so many that an entire wing of the castle is dedicated to them. Orcus notes: "I do not remember how it was when I was born, but I know I did not have any memories of presents and gifts. My earliest memory was of crying."

ORCUS'S DAILY ROUTINE:

To avoid the court's gaze, Orcus stays in the garden reading under an old redwood tree, sunrise to midday, a different book every day (sometimes three or four). Never leaves the shade. Establishes him as a scholar/introvert who hides from attention.

Detail: Passing through a corridor, he pauses at a painting of ladies combing each other's hair - observes it for some time. Suggests a longing for domestic gentleness he doesn't experience.

LADY EMILLEA'S CHAMBERS - FULL DESCRIPTION:

- Scent: Lavender, growing stronger with proximity
- Sound: Laughter echoing from inside
- Interior: Everything new, no dust or dirt; servants by the dozens, but the room is large enough to make them seem like a handful
- Servants' clothing: House Hige colors (blue, orange, green) - some rival Orcus's own clothing in quality
- Courtyard: Grand and lush; trees and bushes "brightly colored green, as if the sun had favored her"; gigantic pillars carved with white bears (House Hige crest)

CONTRAST TABLE:

Queen Mihai	Lady Emillea
Single candlestick	Bright, sunlit rooms
Mold everywhere	Everything new and clean
One thin cover	Lush courtyard
Only Alleria	Dozens of servants
Cold, brittle skin	Youthful, radiant
Lavender = mockery	Lavender = pleasant scent

ORCUS'S ARRIVAL:

A courtesan announces: "Announcing the arrival of His Royal Highness Prince Orcus Emere Patton!"

Emillea: "It is an honor to have you here, my prince." Eyes sparkling with excitement. They hold prolonged eye contact. Orcus notes he'd planned to go unnoticed, but "how does one turn down such a sweet lady?"

He responds warmly: "I am honored, My Lady. Thank you for inviting me." This establishes genuine warmth between Orcus and Emillea - he doesn't hate her the way Iris does.

IRIS'S ARRIVAL - THE POLITICAL STATEMENT:

Iris wears a dark purple dress (House Vika color) falling to the ground, opening at the back, covered head to toe in gems from "Mother's clan," with boars stitched across the bottom (House Vika's symbol). This causes whispers among the guests. She's deliberately making a political statement by wearing full House Vika regalia at a House Hige event.

She sits next to Orcus without speaking to anyone. Her silence is alarming to him - "everything she did was loud."

THE CONFRONTATION - MEETING SOLIS:

Iris demands to see "the prince" - dropping "Lady" from Emillea's title (deliberate insult). A noble lady calls her childish; Iris forces the issue. Emillea sends for Solis.

A servant returns carrying baby Solis "delicately like a prized gem." Emillea angles him toward the twins. Solis smiles and waves his arm, "almost as if he was asking for a hug."

Orcus's internal reaction: "My brother truly is the cutest, but I have to regain my composure." His formal response: "He is beautiful, your highness." Iris's assessment (cold): "He appears healthy." Emillea (laughing): "By the grace of the gods."

THE NOBLE LADIES' INSULTS:

LADY MIADA - speaks first against the twins, calling them bastards who "lack manners"

LADY TIKAN - agrees: "what were you truly expecting from bastards... they are sin against the gods"

LADY ANAIOPANA - calls it a disgrace that the queen "parades around those creatures"; later counsels Emillea to use her "skills" on the king

THE PRIVATE ARGUMENT (ORCUS & IRIS):

Orcus warns Iris about her behavior. The argument escalates to the fundamental question:

Orcus challenges: "Is mother a fool then?" (if beautiful women can be fools, as Iris claims about Emillea).

Iris defends their mother as "a noblewoman born of pure blood" while Emillea "comes from a fallen house. She is not a true noble and is merely a parasite, a leech."

Iris's accusation: Emillea "latched onto our family to boost her own status. Her house has fallen, and she is using our family's position to elevate herself. She stole

Mother's place!"

Orcus finally yells "Enough!" - the entire table turns.

He apologizes to Lady Emillea and leads Iris away.

CHARACTERS INTRODUCED - CHAPTER 1:

PRINCE ORCUS EMERE PATTON (age 5)

Hair: Dark brown (inherited from mother; he despises it). Cuts it shorter than other boys his age to distance himself from mother's look

Eyes: Blue (Patton family trait - "the only thing | he got from Benjamin")

Looks: Identical to his mother, which he resents

Called "the stain of House Patton" behind his back|

Personality: Already bookish (reads daily under a redwood tree). Kind-hearted at this age.

Curious to the point of recklessness (spying on the birth). Wants to embrace Solis as a brother. This chapter shows the origin of his later coldness.

Other: Recognizes Alleria by her footsteps

PRINCE SOLIS ELIAS PATTON (newborn)

Hair: Golden/blonde

Eyes: "Reflecting the image of the sea" (blue)

Skin: "Like milk"

Takes after his father's appearance entirely

Extremely vocal - cries "shattered the very foundation of the castle"

"Fussy like Iris" per Orcus

Orcus thinks the name suits him - "like a sun atop the sky"

KING BENJAMIN LAWERENCE PATTON II

Build: "Rather bulky figure"

Demeanor: Cold, commanding voice even when drunk

Relationship: Holds Solis up with "a look Orcus had never seen" - boastful, full of pride.

Openly dismissive of Queen Mihai. Already planning to ship Iris off to foreign marriage.

"I do not care what has happened to that woman" |

LADY EMILLEA HIGE

Hair: Light brown ("the type of brown comparable to sweets - not gloomy like the twins'")

Eyes: "Mixture of heavy blue and a drop of green, like jewels of the highest cost"

Body: Slender, small waist, ample chest

Skin: "Rather pale but not concerningly so"

Described as "the prettiest woman in all of Aicruae, surpassing even Queen Mihai"

Chambers: Opposite of the queen's - bright, lush, new furniture, lavender scent, dozens of servants in House Hige colors

Character: Shows maternal warmth toward Solis AND genuine kindness toward the twins. Defends Iris and Orcus against ladies who insult them. Calls

them "my children." Refuses to let Iris be married off to Vikistv.

ALLERIA AMECKEN (New character)
Role: Queen Mihai's head maid (her only maid)
Hair: Raven-like, currently tangled
Eyes: Slightly red (crying)
Dress: Modest light purple (House Vika color)
Recognizable by footsteps alone
Normally fearsome - doesn't flinch disciplining the twins. Seeing her grovel is shocking.

MINOR CHARACTERS:
Feriana - pours the king's wine
Pegni - cleans the king's chambers
Count Yainaro - proposes Iris-Vikistv betrothal
The Physician - blue bird mask, black robe
Lady Miada - insults twins as bastards
Lady Tikan - calls twins "sin against the gods"
Lady Anaiopana - counsels Emillea to use "skills"|

WORLDBUILDING CONFIRMED - CHAPTER 1:

- House Hige colors: Blue, orange, green
- House Hige crest: White bear (pillars in courtyard)
- House Patton eyes: Blue, dominant trait "passed down for centuries"
- House Vika color: Purple (Alleria's dress)
- Nerai: Queen Mihai is self-medicating with it; created by Yarsi Vika as "Joyless Death"
- Vikistv betrothal: Cequailian Orana (Sevtor's second son) proposed for Iris
- Vawer Hall: The king's residence within the castle

SEEDS PLANTED - CHAPTER 1:
-> Hair color as legitimacy marker (entire story)
-> Queen Mihai's Nerai use (her eventual death)
-> Iris's amethyst necklace (emotional anchor)
-> Orcus's kindness toward Solis (will be destroyed)
-> Orcus's warmth toward Emillea (makes her death tragic)

t Emillea defending the twins (ironic - they murder her)
-> Lavender as emotional shorthand (Emillea vs. Mihai)
-> "My earliest memory was of crying" - Orcus's childhood
-> The Vikistv betrothal for Iris (payoff: Cequailian
betrothed to Iris later in the war; his father Sevtor
attacks Valea to avenge her)
→ Orcus considering learning archery (fails 3-14, Ch 2)

CHAPTER 2: THE FOREST AND THE LAKE

| Period: | ~7,246 BR (Solis turns 4) |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Lajazer - Royal Castle grounds (birthday celebration), the forest, the Blue Tower, Queen Mihai's chambers, the castle entrance |

| POV: | Split - Iris (Part 1), Orcus (Part 2) |

| Structure: | Two major sections with multiple scenes |

PART ONE: IRIS'S SECTION

POV: Princess Iris Aleka Patton

IRIS'S OPENING MONOLOGUE - HER PSYCHOLOGY:

Iris opens with: "Mother is dying, if she is not already dead..." She is not in denial about Queen Mihai's decline.

Her assessment of Orcus is devastating: "Sometimes I think my twin brother Orcus does not understand me at all. Sometimes I think he might be on the path to becoming exactly like his father." She distinguishes between Orcus's strength (books, logic, knowledge) and his weakness (understanding people, emotional intelligence, political instinct).

On Orcus's approach to Solis: He believes Solis is their brother and that kindness will work. Iris counters:

"Wishing for peace with no plan is as futile as clinging to a dying horse that should be put down."

WHAT ORCUS DOESN'T UNDERSTAND (per Iris):

- Why they're in this predicament
- Why their mother sleeps the way she does

- That even their mother “has begun to resent us for not looking like the king, for being the reason she has been cast aside in favor of some WHORE”
- Iris’s anger at watching Mihai “waste away like water against the sun”

KEY REVELATION: Iris believes Queen Mihai resents the twins for their brown hair - viewing them as the reason she was cast aside. Even their mother partially blames them for not looking like their father.

THE MEMORY DIVIDE:

Iris remembers the golden age - “the time when the king bounced me on my lap and showered me in gifts and titles, the time when mother was constantly smiling.” Orcus apparently doesn’t hold the same memories because he’s younger by minutes: “If he had been born a second earlier, he would remember and he would feel the very anger and disdain I feel in my bones like a second skin.”

On time distortion: “The span of our suffering has become so persistent that it makes it feel as if we had lived a lifetime in it.”

BACKSTORY REVELATIONS:

The Bastard Rumors:

Whispers throughout the years labeling the twins as bastards. The king initially “stood by us, treating us as his own” and promised to always see them as his children. Iris’s bitter assessment: “Funny thing, a promise is.”

The Grandfather’s Death - THE TURNING POINT:

“When my grandfather passed away, the dynamics of the family shifted, and things were never the same again.” This is Duke Rarielo Vika, the protective figure whose death triggered the family’s collapse.

House Vika’s Financial Fall: Queen Mihai’s philosophy: “Money holds the ultimate key to power.” House Vika “suffered a great downfall due to poor investments.” Not survival-threatening, but it brought “shame and dishonor” - their influence vanished overnight. The queen went from “the court’s precious gem and the love of my father’s life” to “a cuckold who was forced to accept what was given to her.”

THE GRANDFATHER - IRIS’S HERO:

DUKE RARIELO VIKA - CHARACTER DETAILS

Title: Duke of House Vika

Character: Great integrity, unwavering support for Queen Mihai. Never flaunted his status. Treated everyone equally "until he had to do the opposite."

His lesson to Iris: "Respect the respectable."

THE VIKA/BOAR PHILOSOPHY (his words):

"Always remember that I am a Vika, that we are| Boars. Wild animals that destroy and wreak havoc simply for crossing our path, if we deem| it necessary, but also always remember to appear gentle and unassuming, until someone gets too close. And learns how different we can| be from regular pigs."

Iris's assessment: "The kind of man you smile at,| the kind of man people respect."

NEW TERM: "Boars" - Vika family identity marker. House Vika's spirit animal is the wild boar. They see themselves as gentle-seeming until provoked, then destructive. Different from "regular pigs" (lesser nobles/commoners). This should go in NOBLE HOUSES.

THE FATHER (Iris's view):

"Quite the opposite" of the grandfather. Called "the drunken fool" in whispers by men who are "found within close proximity to my father" - sycophants who mock him behind his back. Iris notices this irony.

IRIS'S WARNINGS TO ORCUS:

She always tells him what their mother told her. She notes Orcus "likes company... he likes things a king should not, or at least be wary of. But not the kinds of things father does." She fears: "Sometimes I think what Orcus likes will kill him a lot faster than wine."

IRIS'S DEEPEST FEAR:

"And such a thought lingers in your mind, if mother is... gone, and Orcus, my dear, stupid, loveable brother leaves as well, what becomes of me, of that beautiful picture of the evening I spent bouncing on father's lap."

Her fear isn't death - it's being the last one left, holding memories nobody shares. The thought trails off into fragments she can't finish.

On Solis: "Orcus always asks why I cannot love Solis, but how can I he is a parasite."

THE BIRTHDAY CELEBRATION:

Outdoors; sweet smell of cedar, musicians playing, couples dancing, crisp air, sun in Iris's face.

Seating at the great table:

- King Benjamin discusses business with council
- Orcus beside Iris, wearing black suit with gold linings (mirroring the king's attire)
- Lady Emillea and Solis in "striking blue," playing

IRIS'S OBSESSIVE OBSERVATION OF EMILLEA:

After four years of study, Iris catalogs Emillea's physical attributes with increasing darkness: breasts, hair ("prompts violent fantasy of cutting it while she sleeps"), face "like the dolls Iris played with as a child," eyes "emerald green and as bright as gems."

Her thought: "Who could stop me... a woman as low as her is merely an object." She fantasizes about pushing Emillea down and taking her eyes.

Notes Queen Mihai's deterioration: She can no longer have mirrors in her chambers (4 years post-Solis's birth).

THE FAMINE SUBPLOT:

A councilman approaches the king about impending famine, suggesting nobility cut back alongside commoners. The king's response: "I rather choke on my own spit and die than live as commoner." Tells him to use his own riches or be replaced. The councilman flees.

IRIS REQUESTS TO HUNT:

Everyone looks at her "as if she had gone mad like her mother." The king: "Do as you must" - without eye contact. Orcus grabs her hand, voice shaking: "Sister what do you plan on doing?" Iris: "Do not worry brother I shall return as I left."

THE FOREST - IRIS'S SANCTUARY:

The forest is Iris's psychological escape:

- She prefers animals over people
- Animals are "predictable" while humans are not
- Animals cannot lie; their actions "remain true"

- In the forest, "she did not have to think everything was strictly primal"
- She can "express herself however she wanted"

Preparation:

- Hides her shoes behind a tree
- Marks the spot with a torn piece of her black dress
- Removes outer dress, wearing only first three layers
- Lets her hair down completely wild

THE WHITE BEAR ENCOUNTER:

Iris spots reindeer grazing. Before she can shoot, birds become anxious. A low growl shakes the trees and knocks her down. A white bear - 9 feet tall on two feet, twenty yards away. Iris knows running would invite pursuit. She slowly reloads while maintaining eye contact. The bear charges, closing to ten yards. She hits it, reloads, shoots "again and again until she is sure the beast is dead."

Aftermath: Blood soaks her garments. Leaves turn "a ghastly red color." The air smells of "rot and decay." Iris lies on the ground, brings blood-soaked leaves to her nose. The smell of blood reminds her of raspberries. A grin spreads across her face.

TRIPLE SYMBOLISM: The white bear is House Hige's crest animal. Bringing the head to Solis is: (1) a direct insult to his mother's house, (2) proof of her strength, (3) a threat - "A beast will always be a beast" means Solis (and his mother) will always be what they are.

THE RETURN - THE BEAR HEAD SCENE:

Iris strolls into camp carrying the bear's head. Nobles' faces "long and pale." She passes Orcus attempting to mount a horse "twice his size" - he looks "even more pitiful" against it.

The king rises, nearly knocking his cup. Face turns red, eyes bulge. He shouts her name three times. Iris ignores him, places the bear's head in front of a startled Emillea. Emillea jumps back, clutching Solis (whose eyes water). Iris plays with the bear's teeth in a circular motion.

Iris's speech to her father: It was an "awful beast to kill" that took many blows, "but still, in the end, it died." She turns the bear's head to face Emillea. Then,

looking at Solis with his "guiltless eyes," she says: "A beast. will. always. be. a beast."

THE PUNISHMENT:

The king orders: "Guards hear my command; take the princess she has clearly become demented like her mother and lock her in the blue tower she is to receive thirty lashes for her transgressions."

THE BLUE TOWER - CONFIRMED LOCATION

Function: Prison for nobility within the royal castle complex at Lajazer
Named location (not just a description)
Iris receives 30 lashes and 135 days isolation
- no visitors, no letters

Guards grab Iris so hard her arms turn blue. She doesn't fight - "this was not the forest." The nobles (in House Hige colors: orange, blue, green) watch with "noses held high." Iris remembers being called "the gem of the people" - her father from that time "would not have let such dull people touch her."

She looks for purple (House Vika/her mother's color) among the crowd. Instead sees Orcus being held back by a tall knight in dark blue, terror in his face, tears forming. She shakes her head at him.

Her internal mantra as she's dragged: 'this is not the forest this is not the forest this is not the forest this is not the forest' - bites her lip until she tastes blood.

EMILLEA'S INTERVENTION:

Emillea hands Solis to a nanny and rushes to Iris.

The Handkerchief:

- Brightly colored orange with flower-like embroidery
- Smells of lavender and pastries
- Emillea wipes blood off Iris's face
- Places it in Iris's hands, clasping with her own

Emillea's words: "I am sorry... this was meant to be a birthday present for you it's not quite done if you'll forgive me... I know you do not like me very much but I hope I can be your mother you do not have to call me mother if you do not wish to, I just hop-."

Iris cuts her off: "I have a mother already so I shall call you what you truly are Emilea of the fallen."

PART TWO: ORCUS'S SECTION	
POV: Prince Orcus Emere Patton	

OPENING - STRANGE WEATHER:

Birds circling by dozens - unusual. The sky is "lifeless color almost as if a storm was coming yet not quite there." Atmospheric foreboding.

THE TIME SKIP:

135 days (~ 4.5 months) since Iris was sent to the Blue Tower. This is Orcus's first official sparring practice alongside Solis.

Orcus's isolation:

- Usually attended practices with Iris
- She's not allowed visitors or letters
- He hasn't been without her "since even the time before they were born"
- He has "no servants; his twin was not there and his mother was sickly so who would speak on his behalf?"

SOLIS'S ARRIVAL:

More than an hour late. Dressed head to toe in fur (ears still red from cold).

Accompanied by several attendants

in Hige colors plus additional attendants in black and dark blue (given by the king).

None acknowledge Orcus.

Solis offers Orcus his fur: "You can have mine then, I have four other ones here here take it." Orcus refuses: "I don't want your fur, Solis." (Innocent generosity meets growing resentment.)

SER HERT "THE DEAFENING" - FIRST APPEARANCE:

SER HERT "THE DEAFENING"
Role: Weapons instructor for the princes
Skin: Dusky with many impurities
Hands: Rough, full of calluses - "a body built for battle"
Eyes: Hazel - "quite the charmer among the ladies of the court"
Clothing: Olive-green linen shirt, thick brown pants, sword strapped across his back
Demeanor: Loud "in more ways than one." Earned his name during time in the capital. Handsome but "his time in battle made him absent in the heart."
Rumor: A lowborn lady stole his heart

THE SPARRING PRACTICE:

Ser Hert claps his hands: "I take it that means you guys have not [been practicing], well then begin."

Orcus immediately takes a swing at Solis, who is "caught off guard and unprepared to advance" - drops to the ground crying. Attendants rush to dust off Solis.

Ser Hert pulls Orcus into a hug: "A very good job my prince."

Solis (fur coat now brown from dirt): "Brother why would you do that?"

Orcus: "We're practicing not playing a game Solis."

Ser Hert to Solis: "This is not a game you must hone your skill not your empathy."

Solis: "but- it isn't fair"

Ser Hert: "Life isn't fair my prince."

THE ARCHERY COMPETITION:

40 seconds each, shoot as many arrows into center as possible.

- Solis: 14 - Ser Hert pats him cheerfully, attendants clap
- Orcus: 3 - some arrows fall short entirely
- Ser Hert examines target with raised eyebrows: "Disappointing."

- Attendants giggle. Orcus drops his bow, wraps arms around himself against the cold.

Solis tries to hug Orcus: "It's okay brother you did good." Orcus moves sharply away: "I do not need or want your hug Solis." Solis's face drops.

Ser Hert departs: "We will stop here for now my princes I expect to see you back here in a week's time. Remember to practice it is clear it's needed."

QUEEN MIHAI'S CHAMBER - THE PRESSURE:

Orcus visits his mother. Dark brown hair stuck to face with sweat. Lips dry "like she had not drunk a sip of water in weeks." The brown in her eyes has gotten smaller. She bites her nails.

She already knows about the practice: "the castle is not that massive Orcus."

Her rant:

"Look what the bitch has done to your sister... Your sister is the only princess of Aicruae and they degrade her to such extent over a wench and her abomination."

Orcus tries to calm her. She insists: "I will say whatever I like, it is still my castle I have not yet died."

Her prophecy/fear:

"What happens when I die, what happens then, will that bitch push you and your sister out and seat her son on the throne I would rather die a hundred times over before I allow that to happen."

"It is already happening my son do you not understand that, the people of the court question your legitimacy because of that abomination and your father favors it. Your sister is being lashed over it and she will bare those scars for the rest of her days till well after I am gone do you not understand."

She grips her scalp in frustration. Orcus pulls her hands out of her hair and hugs her.

Orcus whispers: "I will get better I promise mother."

TURNING POINT: This is the moment Orcus's kindness begins hardening into obligation and resentment. His mother's pressure transforms his self-improvement from joy into duty.

IRIS'S RETURN - 135 DAYS LATER:

The Royal Castle's exterior described:

- Sits on a huge hill with a long stretch of road
- Cut off from the capital, surrounded by acres of forest
- Exterior is lively and lush (hence "kingdom of the rising sun")
- Completely bannered in House Patton colors: blue & black
- Entrance centered around a statue of a black panther (house protector)

Orcus waits alone, fingers growing numb. A simple wooden carriage arrives with a black panther on its door.

IRIS'S RETURN APPEARANCE:

- Dark brown hair let down
- Medium-length black dress showing knees and ankles
- Opening at the back showing the entire upper half of her back - DISPLAYING HER LASH SCARS
- Small purple rhinestones along the sides
- Wearing the amethyst necklace in the shape of her first initial (father's gift)

They embrace.

Orcus: "You have returned dear sister."

Iris (smiling bittersweetly): "I never left brother."

Orcus notes: "Her eyes still held the same flame from before, that fact brought much comfort to Orcus's heart."

They link arms and walk toward the castle.

THE COURT APPEARANCE - HOUSE KULIO ARRIVES:

Seating:

- Orcus between Lady Emillea and King Benjamin
- Iris to the left of Emillea, beside Solis
- Room is cold; music plays but "appears distant"

COUNT KULIO - DETAILED FIRST APPEARANCE:

COUNT ESERINDEO KULIO (full name from Ch 3)
Described as a "minuscule man"
So close to the king they drop honorifics
Last visited court 6 years prior (when Mihel
was 7)
Jokes with the king like old friends

MIHEL KULIO - FIRST APPEARANCE:

MIHEL KULIO (age 13)
Skin: Light brown
Hair: Black
Eyes: Brown
Described as "a handsome young boy... with a
bright smile"
Introduced by his father as "Michael"
Opposite of his father's appearance (thankfully)

The king assigns Orcus to accompany Mihel during his stay, noting they're "around the same age." Count Kulio jokes: "I do hope the boys don't get into nearly as much trouble as we did at their ages." The king laughs, echoing throughout the room.

WORLDBUILDING CONFIRMED - CHAPTER 2:

- THE BLUE TOWER: Named prison for nobility within the royal castle. Iris held 135 days, 30 lashes, no visitors/letters.
- Royal castle exterior: Hill, forest, blue/black banners, black panther statue at entrance
- House Vika identity: "Boars" - appear gentle, destroy when crossed. Spirit animal = wild boar.
- Duke Rarielo Vika: Iris's grandfather; his death triggered the family's collapse
- House Vika's financial ruin: Bad investments brought shame; overnight loss of influence
- Famine subplot: King refuses to let nobility sacrifice alongside commoners
- Iris in the forest: Primal, free, authentic self vs. court performance

THEMATIC ELEMENTS - CHAPTER 2:

The Forest vs. The Court: Iris is powerful/free in the forest, powerless at court. Her mantra "this is not the forest" shows her compartmentalization.

The Bear Symbolism: House Hige crest animal; a beast Iris conquered; her threat that Solis "will always be a beast."

Orcus's Inadequacy: Fails at archery (3 vs 14), can't mount a horse, no servants, no fur coat, no advocate. His promise to his mother marks the start of his transformation.

Emillea's Attempted Kindness: The handkerchief birthday gift, the offer to be Iris's mother. Iris's total rejection: "Emilea of the fallen." Makes Emillea's later murder more tragic - she tried.

The Scars as Defiance: Iris returns wearing a dress that deliberately displays her lash scars. Both defiance and a badge of honor.

CHAPTER 3: THE REFLECTION ON THE WALL

| Period: | ~7,243 BR (Solis turns 7) |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Lajazer - Royal Castle (the Great Table, the ballroom, Lady Emillea's chambers, the physician's quarters in the lower castle) |

| POV: | Prince Solis Elias Patton (first person) |

| Structure: | Two parts - The Ball; The Miscarriage |

	PART ONE: THE BALL	
	Location:	The Great Table, the ballroom

THE SETTING - THE GREAT TABLE:

Solis watches from the great table, which he notes has "three empty chairs": one empty "for a long time" (Queen Mihai's - even before her death), two newly empty (the twins, who are away).

King Benjamin and Lady Emillea are "mesmerized by one another drinking out of each other's cups" - Emillea

"comfortably on my father's lap." She is visibly pregnant, "gently rubbing her swollen stomach," legs shaky - the king has "clearly overexerted her" during dancing.

SOLIS'S INTERNAL CONFLICT:

He questions what the festivities are honoring: his birth? The queen's death? His coming sibling? He sees that "not one of them looks upon me with sinless eyes."

On Queen Mihai's death: "When someone dies we're supposed to mourn yet not once in the four months since the queen has passed has the castle hung a black banner. Did she not deserve honor?"

On his father's pattern: "If he can toss her aside as if she is nothing, are we all as easily replaceable to him, when do we get replaced?" He wonders if his mother will suffer the same fate.

THE TWINS' ABSENCE:

Four months since the twins left for the dukedom of Vika (Queen Mihai's birthplace). House Vika "has long since left the court" - "Left is a sweet word to use though since it is not like they had much of a choice."

Color dynamics: Solis misses seeing "a singular splash of purple among the green, orange, and blue." Purple = House Vika (absent); green, orange, blue = House Hige (dominant).

Solis on House Hige: "Mother says the people wearing those colors are my family but they seem more like snakes, especially grandfather he says he wants to bring back honor to our house."

NEW DETAIL: Emillea's father (Solis's maternal grandfather) is present at court and ambitious about restoring House Hige's honor. Solis sees through him.

THE KING'S INTERACTION:

Benjamin notices Solis looking troubled. Solis lies: "I am simply wondering where the young ladies are." The king: "You are indeed just like your father" (while brushing Emillea's face). His face is "blush shade of pink," eyes "sloppy" - clearly drunk.

Emillea leans down to Solis and murmurs: "Pick well my son." (Advising him about the Kulio daughters.)

SOLIS ON BEING ALONE:

"I sit alone, I have gotten used to being alone being alone is not so bad. I have found that constantly being surrounded by people can prove exhausting."

"I do not wish for what they have." (His parents')

passionate relationship.)

THE KULIO FAMILY ARRIVES:

Announcement: "Count Kulio and his two eldest daughters Lady Harnua Kulio and Lady Esterica Kulio."

The king "jumps up from his seat like his pants are on fire."

COUNT KULIO - SOLIS'S ASSESSMENT:

COUNT ESERINDEO KULIO (full name confirmed)

Hair: Bright red

Skin: Fawn

Build: "Short stubby man"

Temperament: "Unbefitting of his height"

Age: Nearly 47

Wives: Currently on his 7th (24 years younger)

"Looking like a creature found in the depths of the forest"

Only person Solis has "ever seen hit father" (jokingly, on the shoulder)

So close to the king they drop all honorifics

Per Solis: "House Kulio seems to resemble a brothel rather than a House worthy of virtue"

Age gap revealed: Lady Emillea "was much younger than Count Kulio's wife when she and my father wed, at the mere nineteen years of age she was betrothed to a man fourteen years her senior." (Benjamin ~33, Emillea ~19.)

HARNUA KULIO - FIRST APPEARANCE (age ~8):

Build: Slender yet curved

Skin: Dark brown

Height: Tall

Hair: Long, flowy black - falls to her feet

Eyes: Deep-set, light brown

Features: Tiny mole beside her lips; heart-shaped lips

"A truly beautiful girl"

BUT: "She appears empty as if she is missing something like a doll, even her movements seem like they're guided by a piece of string."

Parentage: Same mother as Mihel (1st wife)

Favors her mother - "thankfully an awful sin it

would be to look like him"

Her greeting: "Harnua Kulio of the great house
Kulio, greets his royal highness the second
sun of Aicruae."

Her smile: "Telling... shows boredom... forced... |
carefully prepared beforehand. Her eyes do not
show adoration instead they show indifference."

Solis's verdict: "I would rather be skinned alive
than be with someone with the personality of
a wall."

NEW DETAIL: Solis is called "the second sun of Aicruae." Orcus is "the First Sun" (heir), Iris is "the First Moon" (eldest girl/only princess).

ESTERICA KULIO - FIRST APPEARANCE (age ~5):

Entry: Count Kulio has to pull her out from
behind Harnua - "Esterica stop cloaking within
your sister let the prince see you."
Height: Same as Harnua despite being 3 years
younger than her and 2 years younger than Solis
Build: Thin waist, fuller figure than her sister
Skin: Fawn (inherited from father)
Eyes: Beautiful blue, cat-like in shape
Lips: Full heart-shaped (both upper and lower)
Cheekbones: Well-defined
Hair: Long golden - "Like mine, this is the first
time I have ever seen someone with hair as
golden as mine outside of our House"
Scent: Nutmeg ("the scent of home")
Clothing: Golden-yellow dress with white flower
embroidery - doesn't fit properly (falls to
the ground "quite harshly") - clearly someone
else's. Simple silver necklace, "rather boring."|
Her greeting (less formal than Harnua's):
"Esterica Kulio of house Kulio greets the
prince." Bow "not as generous as her sister's"
- one shoulder leans to the side.
Parentage: Mother is Count Kulio's 4th wife,

"one of his favorite ones"

THE HAND KISS - SOLIS'S DECLARATION:

Solis bows a second time (unusual protocol - draws
notice). Esterica "scoffs slightly" but no one else
notices.

He takes her hand and kisses it. Gasps from everyone, including his father. The entire party "lit aflame" with whispers that outshine the music.

Solis's experience: "Everything disappears and it's just me and Lady Esterica standing there, everything is still but my heart. It's the first time it has ever beat so fast." Her smell - nutmeg - has "overtaken me... the scent of home."

On seeing her: "She looks stunning. I want this. How do I get more of this? ...How do I get her?"

Esterica: Eyes wide, face blushing, "looks stuck." She pulls her arm "sharply away" and retreats behind Harnua.

Solis after: "It was nice not feeling alone for a moment. Her hands were warm but now I am once again shrouded in coldness, I miss her touch."

THE KING'S WARNING:

Benjamin grabs Solis privately:

"Be careful my dear son... do not let yourself be swayed you must marry the oldest Kulio daughter you may bed the other after the first births your heir only after the heir is born may you have her. Do you understand me?"

Political expectation: Marry Harnua (eldest), take Esterica only after Harnua produces an heir. The king is ordering Solis to repeat his own Mihai/Emillea pattern.

Solis's internal defiance:

"I do not understand. What is so wrong with wanting her?"

"Would mother want me to marry the first daughter and keep the other as my whore?"

"I do not want to make Esterica a whore and I do not wish to use and hold Lady Harnua and simply toss her aside."

"Are we not allowed to choose for ourselves our own fates?"

Solis on his feelings: "I want Esterica even in this vast crowd of people I can only see her, she is my light... it cannot be love, for this is my first time ever meeting her it is too soon for it to be called such a significant word. But I want to see more of her, and I miss her already despite her being across the ballroom."

THE MOTHERS WITH DAUGHTERS:

After the king leaves, Solis is swarmed by mothers peddling their daughters. He calls them "snakes set on selling their daughters to me."

He observes the king scanning the room "as he has done before. In search of something... or someone or what's left of them at least." (Suggests the king may be looking for traces of the dead queen - guilt?)

PART TWO: THE MISCARRIAGE

Location: Lady Emillea's chambers, the corridor, the physician's quarters (lower castle)

THE CRY IN THE NIGHT:

"A loud cry wakes me out of my slumber, the cry is piercing as if the gods themselves was punishing the person."

Solis rushes to his mother's chambers.

THE SCENE:

Emillea on the floor in a pool of blood, one arm stretched to the sky, the other on her stomach.

Emillea's words:

"Please forgive me."

"The Queen she has taken my child."

"She has taken your brother."

"I cannot feel him anymore."

SER HERT REAPPEARS:

Solis finds Ser Hert during the guards' shift change.

After gasping out "Bleeding... Blood... Floor... Baby," Ser Hert rushes to Emillea's chambers and carries her to the physician.

The physician: "A rather old woman who was once a wet nurse." Chambers in the lower castle. She saves Emillea but not the child: "I managed to save the lady... the young prince however did not make it."

Ser Hert takes his sword off his back, kneels, and begins to pray.

SOLIS'S RESPONSE:

"The room reeked of blood, but I did not mind I was simply happy mother was okay, that I did not lose her too." He hugs her and cries "till my eyes hurt."

THE FINAL EXCHANGE:

Solis hears his mother mutter in her sleep: "She did this..."

Solis responds quietly - with remarkable maturity for a 7-year-old:

"She did not do this... The queen was not responsible for this, for she is gone.

Father did this, Grandfather did this but the queen did not it was not her fault. The gods designed this and this was simply his fate, we cannot blame those who do

not control the outcome or the beginning. We must not blame the victim only the perpetrator, even if the queen was to have caused this... It was not her fault."

This directly contrasts with the twins' blame-driven hatred. Solis refuses to perpetuate the cycle. He identifies the real culprits: his father and grandfather (the system), not the dead queen (the scapegoat).

WORLDBUILDING CONFIRMED - CHAPTER 3:

- Court color dynamics: Purple (Vika, absent), green/ orange/blue (Hige, dominant), yellow (Kulio)
- House Vika left court after Queen Mihai's death; went to the dukedom of Vika (Haleker)
- Solis's title: "the second sun of Aicruae"
- Orcus's title: "the First Sun of Aicruae"
- Iris's title: "the First Moon of Aicruae"
- Count Kulio's full name: Eserindeo Kulio
- Count Kulio's hair: Bright red; skin: fawn
- Harnua's mother: Count Kulio's first wife (same as Mihel's mother)
- Esterica's mother: Count Kulio's fourth wife
- Lady Emillea's age at marriage: ~19 (king was ~33)
- The miscarried child was a boy - Solis would have had a younger brother
- Solis's maternal grandfather (House Hige patriarch) is at court and ambitious
- Political expectation: Solis to marry Harnua, take Esterica as mistress after heir is born

SEEDS PLANTED - CHAPTER 3:

- Solis-Esterica matching golden hair (eventual marriage)
- Harnua's emptiness/doll-like quality (eventual zealotry fills the void)
- The miscarried brother deepens Emillea's fragility
- Emillea blaming Queen Mihai's ghost - supernatural thinking shows the court runs on paranoia and grudges
- Solis refusing to blame the queen - moral difference from the twins; he won't perpetuate the cycle (until

the war changes him)
→ The king ordering Solis to repeat his pattern (marry the elder, bed the younger) - Solis ultimately defies this by marrying Esterica, but then DOES take Tixsei as second wife after Esterica's death, partially fulfilling the pattern anyway
→ "I do not wish for what they have" - Solis doesn't want his parents' kind of love. He wants something real. He gets it with Esterica, then loses it.
→ Esterica's ill-fitting dress - she's from the lower ranks of House Kulio. Not the prized eldest daughter. A borrowed dress for a borrowed position.

APPENDIX: NEW HUB DOCUMENT CROSS-REFERENCES FROM CHAPTERS 1-3

The following new information was discovered in the deep dives and should be distributed to hub documents:

IN STORY CHARACTERS (new entries needed):

- Alleria Amecken - Queen Mihai's head maid
- Ser Hert "the Deafening" - weapons instructor
- Feriana - pours the king's wine
- Pegni - cleans the king's chambers
- Lady Miada, Lady Tikan, Lady Anaiopana - noble ladies
- Count Yainaro - proposes Iris-Vikistv betrothal

IN STORY CHARACTERS (updates to existing entries):

- Harnua Kulio - first physical description at age 8
- Esterica Kulio - first physical description at age 5
- Count Kulio - full name: Eserindeo Kulio; red hair, fawn skin, 7 wives, 47 years old
- King Benjamin II - "bulky figure," drunk behavior
- Queen Mihai - full deterioration details, Nerai use
- Iris - "the First Moon of Aicruae" title
- Orcus - "the First Sun of Aicruae" title, daily reading routine, redwood tree

- Solis - "the second sun of Aicruae" title

NOBLE HOUSES (new details):

- House Vika: "Boar" identity philosophy (grandfather's speech); financial ruin from bad investments
- House Hige: Colors confirmed (blue, orange, green); Solis's maternal grandfather at court, ambitious
- House Patton: Blue eyes dominant trait "for centuries"; castle exterior details

LOCATIONS (new entries):

- THE BLUE TOWER - prison for nobility within royal castle at Lajazer
- VAWER HALL - the king's residence within the castle
- Royal Castle exterior description (hill, forest, banners, panther statue)
- Lady Emillea's courtyard (white bear pillars)

KEY WORDS AND TERMS (new entries) :

- "THE FIRST SUN OF AICRUAE" - Orcus's title
- "THE FIRST MOON OF AICRUAE" - Iris's title
- "THE SECOND SUN OF AICRUAE" - Solis's title
- "THE GEM OF THE PEOPLE" - Iris's former nickname

QUOTE BANK (potential additions):

- Orcus: "Above Human, Below God" reflection
- Iris: "A beast. will. always. be. a beast."
- Iris: "I have a mother already so I shall call you what you truly are Emilea of the fallen."
- Queen Mihai: "I wish I had held your father more tightly. Your mother is sorry."
- Duke Rarielo Vika: The "Boars" speech
- Solis (age 7): "We must not blame the victim only the perpetrator"
- Ser Hert: "Life isn't fair my prince."

- King Benjamin: "I do not care what has happened to that woman."

HISTORICAL FIGURES (updates) :

- Duke Rarielo Vika - expanded characterization; death as the family's collapse trigger

CHAPTER 4: THE DAMNED

Period: ~7,241 BR (Solis turns 9)
 Location: Lajazer (Royal Castle), Festival of Mourning
 POV Focus: Solis, Harnua, the twins

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - age 9; named heir

King Benjamin II - names Solis heir at the Festival of Mourning; dies 4 months later

Harnua - meets Orcus for the first time under a tree while he cries; she wipes his tears; instant connection

Orcus - age 15; mourning his mother; bonds with Harnua

Iris - age 15; leads the coup; poisons Lady Emillea publicly, forces crowd to laugh

Lady Emillea Hige - poisoned to death during the coup; Solis watches from beneath a floorboard

MAJOR BEATS:

- Festival of Mourning (supposed to honor the dead) King Benjamin names 9-year-old Solis as heir, bypassing the twins
- Harnua meets Orcus for the first time; he's crying under a tree mourning his mother; she wipes his tears; they talk for hours
- HARNUA FALLS FOR ORCUS (age 9/15)
- 4 months after the festival, the king dies suddenly
- 2 weeks after the king's death: THE TWINS' COUP
- Solis and his mother attempt to escape; Emillea is caught

- Iris forces Emillea to drink poison in front of a crowd of onlookers who are forced to laugh
- Solis watches from beneath a floorboard as his mother dies
- Solis escapes

SEEDS PLANTED:

→ The Festival of Mourning as a political event (payoff: KEY WORDS AND TERMS entry)

-> Harnua's love for Orcus begins at age 9 (payoff: her entire arc - saint to zealot to murderer)
 -> Iris's capacity for theatrical cruelty (forcing the crowd to laugh) established early
 -> Solis's defining trauma: watching his mother die (payoff: the letter campaign Ch 17, his breakdown Ch 60, his entire revenge arc)
 -> The king's "sudden death" - mysterious circumstances never fully resolved

ARC II: EXILE & RETURN

Chapters 5-9 | ~7,234 BR - 7,221 BR | Pre-War

Focus: Solis's 20-year exile, his transformation from traumatized boy to military commander, Mihel's double agency, and Solis's infiltration of the twins' court.

CHAPTER 5: THE SUN, THE MOON, AND TRUTH

Period: ~7,234 BR (Solis is ~16)
 Location: The Mystic Isles
 POV Focus: Solis

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - flees to Mystic Isles; trains; pledges to Razar; adopts alias "Jonathan Kiva"; dyes hair red; builds army of 30,000
 Razar, God of the Sun - accepts Solis's pledge; grants war tactics ability in exchange for a strand of hair

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis arrives at the Mystic Isles and begins training
- SOLIS PLEDGES TO RAZAR - exchanges a strand of his hair for the ability to devise war tactics
- Solis dyes his hair red to disguise himself
- Adopts the alias "Jonathan Kiva"
- Joins a mercenary group; rises to general
- Builds an army of more than 30,000 men (by age 16)

SEEDS PLANTED:

- Razar's divine contract (payoff: Razar blinds Dame Kisaleli in Ch 62; Razar identifies Harnua in Ch 68)
- The alias "Jonathan Kiva" / "Janrano Kiva" (payoff:

name discrepancy between Ch 5 and Ch 6 - confirm which is canon)
-> Solis's military genius is divinely sourced, not innate (payoff: complicates the "self-made king" narrative)

CHAPTER 6: GOLD AND MEN'S GREED

Period:	~ 7, 230 s BR (Solis late teens/twenties)
:—	:—
Location:	The Mystic Isles (neutral zone)
POV Focus:	Mihel, Solis

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis / "Jonathan Kiva" - mercenary general; identity discovered by Mihel
Mihel Kulio - alarmed by a "nobody" controlling 30,000 men; exchanges letters with "Janrano Kiva"; meets him on the Mystic Isles; uncovers his true identity

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis's mercenary group attracts Mihel's attention
- Mihel writes to "Janrano Kiva" - they agree to meet on the Mystic Isles (neutral ground)

- Mihel suspects Jonathan Kiva isn't who he claims
- Works to get Solis to lower his guard
- Solis reveals his true identity
- They form an alliance to bring down the twins

NAME NOTE:

Ch 5 uses "Jonathan Kiva"; Ch 6 uses "Janrano Kiva" in Mihel's letter. Confirm: is Jonathan the commontongue name and Janrano the Ananara version? Or is one a typo?

SEEDS PLANTED:

- Mihel's role as the fixer/double agent begins here
- The Mystic Isles as neutral meeting ground (payoff: Ch 10 - they return here to plan the rebellion; post-war - Mihel retires here)

CHAPTER 7: SIN

Period:	~ 7,230 s — 7,220 s BR
Location:	Lajazer (capital city), Southern Aicruae
POV Focus:	Solis, Mihel

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis / Jonathan Kiva - meets the twins in disguise;
sent to handle southern revolt
Mihel - arranges the meeting; warns Solis about spies
Orcus - agrees to deploy "Kiva" against southern rebels
Iris - present at the meeting

MAJOR BEATS:

- Mihel and Solis arrive in Lajazer
- Mihel arranges a face-to-face meeting between Solis (as Jonathan Kiva) and the twins - the twins have no idea who he really is
- Tense meeting; Orcus agrees to put Solis in charge of stopping a revolt in southern Aicruae

- Solis arrives in southern Aicruae - witnesses firsthand the effects of the twins' rule on the people
- Mihel warns Solis about spies in his army; suggests planting false information to smoke out the mole
- Solis plants false news; spy revealed; Solis slits his throat silently
- Solis continues sending "updates" to Orcus as the spy

SEEDS PLANTED:

- > Solis sees the cost of the twins' rule on ordinary people (payoff: his initial idealism about fixing the kingdom)
- > Solis's capacity for quiet, efficient violence (slit throat, impersonating the spy) - he's already dangerous
- > Mihel's strategic mind: the false-information trap

CHAPTER 8: A MOUTH WELL SPOKEN

Period: ~2 years after Ch 7 (Solis late 20s)
 Location: Southern Aicruae, then Lajazer (capital)
 POV Focus: Solis, Iris

KEY CHARACTERS:

- Solis - allies with the rebels instead of killing them; returns with a traitor's head; knighted; assigned to guard Iris
- Orcus - rewards Solis with gold and the title of royal knight; places him in charge of guarding Iris
- Iris - subjects Solis to extreme psychological torture (the Lady Emillea scene)

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis finds the rebel hideout - instead of killing them, offers assistance and proposes an alliance
- Returns to the capital 2 years later with the "rebel leader's head" - actually a traitor who was working for Orcus
- Orcus awards Solis: gold, title of royal knight, placed in charge of guarding Iris

- IRIS SCENE: On his first assignment guarding Iris, she forces Solis to watch as she masturbates using the stuffed body of Lady Emillea Hige
- Solis rushes out, vomits, stabs himself in the thigh repeatedly to stop himself from killing Iris
- Returns to the room and continues watching
- Iris calls him “weak-bodied,” insults his mother, continues using Emillea’s body

CONTENT NOTE:

This is one of the story’s most disturbing scenes. Iris’s desecration of Emillea’s body is both sexual and political - it’s dominance, not just cruelty. Solis’s self-harm (thigh stabbing) to maintain control establishes his capacity for self-inflicted pain in service of the long game.

SEEDS PLANTED:

- Solis’s 11-year infiltration of the court begins
- The depth of Iris’s hatred for Emillea/Solis
- Solis’s self-harm as coping mechanism
- The rebels become Solis’s secret southern allies

CHAPTER 9: THE ART OF DESTRUCTION

| Period: | ~ 7, 221 BR (Solis is 29; twins turn 35) |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Lajazer - Iris’s estate, Royal Castle, ball |

| POV Focus: | Solis, Esterica |

| KEY CHARACTERS: | |

| | Solis - age 29; still serving as Iris’s personal guard; hatred growing daily |

| | Iris - age 35; birthday ball; walks over Solis to reach her carriage; makes him dress her |

| | Orcus - age 35; birthday ball |

| | Esterica Kulio - returns from the countryside; special appearance at the ball; approaches Solis |

| | Mihel Kulio - present at the ball |

Harnua Kulio - present at the ball

MAJOR BEATS:

- 11 years have passed since Solis re-entered the capital

- He is still Iris's personal guard; hates her more daily
- Twins' 35th birthday ball
- Iris makes Solis fit her into her gown; walks over him to get to her carriage
- All Kulio siblings present: Mihel, Harnua, Esterica
- Esterica and Solis's eyes meet across the ball
- HE PULLS AWAY FIRST - because he notices they no longer share the same hair color (callback to Ch 3)
- Esterica walks over, asks if they've met before
- Solis denies it (though he wants to speak with her)
- Esterica shrugs it off and returns to her family
- Solis is left alone staring at the ball - "the kind of ball he used to have"

SEEDS PLANTED:

- Solis-Esterica reunion sets up their romance
- The hair color change: Esterica's hair has changed since childhood (or Solis has been dyeing his red) the connection that first drew them together has shifted
- This is the last chapter before the war begins

ARC III: YEAR ONE OF THE WAR

Chapters 10 — 21 | 7,221 BR

Focus: The civil war ignites. Solis claims the throne, Esterica infiltrates his army, international alliances form, trench warfare at Jasereiey, and Iris's abduction of Yera.

CHAPTER 10: THE WAKE

Period: 7,221 BR - Year One begins

Location: Mystic Isles, Lajazer (capital), Western Aicruae

POV Focus: Solis, Mihel, Orcus, Iris

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - announces his claim to the throne; attacks the capital's food supply

Mihel - returns to the capital to "aid" the twins
(continuing double agent role)

MAJOR BEATS:

- Mihel and Solis meet on the Mystic Isles - decide it's finally time to rebel
- Solis spreads word of his identity and stakes a claim for the throne
- Capital thrown into gossip; twins scramble
- Solis attacks the capital's food supply as his army moves through western Aicruae
- Mihel returns to capital to "aid" Orcus and Iris (still playing double agent)

CHAPTER 11: WHEREVER THE PIECES MAY FALL

| Period: |

| :— |

| Location: |

| POV Focus: |

| KEY CHARACTERS: |

| Esterica - infiltrates Solis's army, nearly dying to prove loyalty; Solis locks her in a room |

| Harnua - offers to use her powers to kill Solis |

| Orcus - tells Harnua not to use powers (fear of gods' wrath); rejects her confession of love |

| Iris - appoints herself general; slits current general's throat; hangs his head on a pole |

MAJOR BEATS:

- Esterica nearly gets herself killed infiltrating Solis's army to prove she supports him
- Solis locks Esterica in a room while he figures out how she got in
- Harnua offers to kill Solis with her powers
- Orcus refuses - warns using saintly powers to kill a mortal might bring divine wrath
- HARNUA CONFESSES HER LOVE TO ORCUS

- Orcus rejects her - says he sees her as a little sister
- Iris takes over western army command; kills the current general (slits throat, hangs head on pole)
- YEAR ONE OFFICIALLY BEGINS

SEEDS PLANTED:

→ Orcus's rejection of Harnua (payoff: she never stops

trying; this rejection festers for the entire war)
 Tris's command style: rule by terror from day one
 t Esterica's willingness to risk death to reach Solis

CHAPTER 12: THE ONE ABOVE IT ALL

Period: 7,221 BR - Year One
 Location: Capital, neighboring country (unnamed),
 Western Aicruae
 POV Focus: Orcus, Iris, Solis
 KEY CHARACTERS:
 Orcus - invades a neighboring country for food; fails
 Iris - killing her own men as examples; army camps
 surrounded and overrun
 Solis - moves second army to eastern Aicruae; cuts
 off trade supply
 MAJOR BEATS:
 - Orcus's army underperforming; food depleting
 - Orcus invades a neighboring country to balance food supply - fails; invaded country enters famine
 - Orcus sends 10,000 men to help Iris; discovers she's been killing her own soldiers as examples
 - Solis surrounds Iris's camp; she barely escapes
 - Iris returns to capital barely alive, in shambles
 - Solis moves a second army to eastern Aicruae - cuts off Orcus's trade supply

CHAPTER 13: ALL THE KING'S MEN

Period: 7,221 BR - Year One
 Location: Western Aicruae (agricultural sites),
 Quather Sea
 POV Focus: Esterica, Orcus

KEY CHARACTERS:

Esterica - sets up new agricultural sites for Solis's army (winter prep)

Orcus - launches surprise attack from the Quather Sea

Iris - suspects a traitor in their ranks

Mihel - loyalty questioned

MAJOR BEATS:

- Esterica establishes agricultural infrastructure to

feed Solis's army through winter

- Orcus launches surprise sea attack from the Quather
- Both twins suspect a traitor - Mihel's loyalty questioned

SEEDS PLANTED:

→ Esterica as agricultural reformer/soft-power strategist (payoff: her legacy - libraries, reforms)

→ Mihel's cover starting to thin

CHAPTER 14: A KING'S RANSOM

Period:	7,221 BR - Year One
Location:	Conquered territories, capital city
POV Focus:	Solis, Harnua, Iris, Mihel
KEY CHARACTERS:	
	Solis - demeans each captured territory; conscripts men
	Harnua - position shaky; people question her relationship with Orcus despite her sainthood
	Iris - rooting out spies; narrows suspicion on Mihel
	Mihel - forced to decide: continue double agency or flee before the twins find him out

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis supplies his army by conscripting men from conquered territories

- Harnua's relationship with Orcus becoming a liability - people question a saint's closeness to the king
- Iris hunting for spies; zeroing in on Mihel
- Mihel faces his critical choice: stay or go

CHAPTER 15: THE FLOWER THAT BLOOMS

Period:	7,221 BR - Year One
Location:	Solis's base camp
POV Focus:	Iris, Solis

KEY CHARACTERS:

Iris - leads surprise attack on Solis's base camp

Solis - defends; loses 500 men but survives; fully prepared for her next move

MAJOR BEATS:

- Iris's surprise attack on Solis's camp to avenge previous loss
- Solis barely defends; 500 men lost
- Solis is already prepared for her next planned attack

CHAPTER 16: THE SWEETEST FRUIT

Period:	7,221 BR - Year One
Location:	Western Aicruae (agricultural fields)
POV Focus:	Solis, Harnua

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - poisons agricultural fields as a trap; Orcus's best general and close friend dies

Harnua - uses her position as head of the church to turn people against Solis; calls the poisoning a religious sacrilege

MAJOR BEATS :

- Solis abandons western agricultural fields and "surrenders" them to Orcus - BUT the fields are poisoned
- Orcus's best general and close friend dies from the poisoning
- Orcus forced into a more battle-ready position
- Harnua steps up as head of the church; uses her position to turn people against Solis, calling the poisoning "religious sacrilege"

SEEDS PLANTED:

- Solis's willingness to weaponize food/agriculture (the thing Esterica is building)
- moral complexity
- Harnua's political power through the church

CHAPTER 17: TEARS OF THE HOLY

| Period: | 7,221 BR - Year One |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Aicruae (kingdom-wide), capital city |

| POV Focus: | Orcus, Solis, Iris |

| KEY CHARACTERS: | |

| Orcus - deals with loss of 27,000 men | |

| Solis - writes and distributes his "letter" about watching his mother die; cries on Esterica's shoulder | |

| Esterica - emotional support for Solis | |

| Iris - returns to find public opinion turned against | |

her; goes on a rampage; kills 9 people; cries on the floor covered in blood

MAJOR BEATS:

- Orcus has lost 27,000 men
- SOLIS'S LETTER CAMPAIGN: Writes a letter describing watching his mother poisoned by Iris; distributes it throughout Aicruae
- Public opinion turns against Iris

- Solis cries on Esterica's shoulder
- Iris returns to capital - receives disgusted looks
- Goes on a rampage; kills 9 people
- Chapter ends with Iris crying on the floor, covered in blood, remembering how people used to look at her after her mother's death

THEMATIC NOTE:

This chapter establishes Iris's cycle: public rejection → violence → private grief. She's been performing since childhood (the dress showing her lash scars, Ch 2). Now the performance is failing. The image of her crying in blood while remembering her mother's death is a mirror of Solis hiding under his bedsheet hearing his mother scream (Ch 3).

CHAPTER 18: THROUGH THE HANDS OF ANOTHER

| Period: | 7,221 BR - Year One |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Jasereiey |

| POV Focus: | Solis, Orcus |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - invades Jasereiey; fights personally; takes out 100+ men single-handedly; fame spreads internationally
 Orcus - sends forces to counter; heavy losses on both sides
 Duke Reasaec Kivier (envoy) - Equateiy declares it will fund Orcus's war effort
 Gherci envoy - offers funding to Solis (religious motivation: twins' actions against the gods' will)

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis invades Jasereiey
- Major battle - heavy casualties on both sides
- Solis fights personally; kills 100+ men solo

- Word spreads internationally - attracts attention
- INTERNATIONAL ALLIANCES FORM:
- Equateiy (Duke Reasaec Kivier) → backs Orcus
- Gherci → backs Solis (religious justification)

CHAPTER 19: KNIGHTS VOW

| Period: | 7,221 BR - Year One |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Jasereiey (trench warfare) |

| POV Focus: | Solis, Esterica, Mihel |

| KEY CHARACTERS: | |

| Solis - trench warfare over Jasereiey's mineral mines; men convince him to leave the front lines | |

| Mihel - feeling insecure now that both sisters are protected (Harnua by the church, Esterica by Solis); decides to leave before the twins discover him | |

MAJOR BEATS:

- Trench warfare at Jasereiey - fighting over mineral mines
- Solis's men convince him to leave the front lines; he reluctantly agrees
- Solis and Esterica begin discussing a union (marriage)
- Mihel feels his position slipping - both sisters now have protectors
- Mihel decides to leave the twins' court before his cover is blown

CHAPTER 20: THE WILTING OF THE ROSE

Period: 7,221 BR - Year One

Location: Pireaynea, capital city

POV Focus: Orcus, Iris

KEY CHARACTERS:

Orcus - sends 10,000 men to crush Pireaynean revolt;
captures slaves as soldiers

Iris - falls for slave girl Yera (resembles Solis's
mother); takes her as personal maid; forces her into
becoming her "wife"

Yera - enslaved; brought from Pireaynea; despises Iris

MAJOR BEATS:

- Pireaynea revolts against Orcus

- Orcus sends 10,000 men; captures slaves for soldiers
- IRIS MEETS YERA - a slave girl brought from Pireaynea who resembles Solis's mother (Lady Emillea)
- Iris takes Yera as personal maid, tortures her, forces her into becoming her "wife"
- Iris's "love" is obsessive - cannot understand why Yera doesn't reciprocate; doesn't see her own abuse as wrong because it's the only way she knows to show love
- Meanwhile: Orcus has grown up with a complete emotional blockage toward love (parents' troubled relationship)

THEMATIC NOTE:

The Yera connection to Lady Emillea is devastating. Iris is obsessed with a girl who looks like the woman she murdered. This is not coincidence; it's the trauma loop made literal.

CHAPTER 21: THE BEAR AND THE BOAR

Period: 7,221 BR - Year One ends

Location: Jasereiey (victory), capital city

POV Focus: Solis, Orcus, Iris

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - wins Jasereiey; celebrates with Esterica

Orcus - enraged; orders all his generals beheaded for losing

Iris - carries out the beheadings (only general spared because she's his sister)

Yera - witnesses the beheadings from a distance; runs from Iris

MAJOR BEATS:

- Orcus withdraws from Jasereiey - major Solis victory
- Solis celebrates with a night of passion with Esterica
- Orcus visibly angry for the first time - feels betrayed by Mihel (former close friend)

- Orders all his war generals beheaded for failure
- Iris carries out the executions (she's the only general spared - she's his sister)
- Yera witnesses the beheadings; Iris sees her; Yera runs; Iris chases her

YEAR ONE SUMMARY:

Solis: Wins Jasereiey, gains Gherci backing, cuts off

eastern trade. Esterica building agricultural base.
 Orcus: Loses Jasereiey, gains Equateiy funding, purges his own generals.
 Iris: Nearly killed, loses public favor, begins Yera obsession.
 Mihel: Cover nearly blown; transitions from double agent to open Solis supporter.
 Harnua: Rejected by Orcus; consolidates church power.

ARC IV: YEAR TWO - THE GOLDEN KING

Chapters 22-28 | 7,220 BR

Focus: Solis and Esterica marry, the famous tea party, Mihel's losses, and Harnua's betrayal of her brother.

CHAPTER 22: [UNTITLED]

Period: 7,220 BR - Year Two begins

Location: Bareta (Orcus's stronghold)

POV Focus: Orcus

KEY CHARACTERS:

Orcus - attacks Bareta; kills 200+ women and children; enslaves the men

MAJOR BEATS:

- Orcus attacks Solis's position at Bareta to avenge Year One losses
- MASSACRE AT BARETA: 200+ women and children killed; men enslaved

CHAPTER 23: [UNTITLED]

Period: 7,220 BR - Year Two

Location: Bareta

POV Focus: Mihel, Iris

KEY CHARACTERS:

Mihel - becomes captain of Solis's second army; leads

battle to recover Bareta; LOSES HIS LEFT EYE
Iris - wins the battle of Bareta

MAJOR BEATS:

- Mihel promoted to captain of Solis's second army
- Leads the counterattack to recover Bareta
- Iris wins the battle
- MIHEL LOSES HIS LEFT EYE

CHAPTER 24: [UNTITLED]

Period:	7,220 BR - Year Two
Location:	Valea (Orcus's third stronghold)
POV Focus:	Solis

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - attacks and captures Valea; kills 800 men but spares women and children

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis attacks Valea (Orcus's third most powerful stronghold)
- Kills 800 of Orcus's men
- Sparing the women and children (contrast with Orcus's massacre at Bareta)

CHAPTER 25: GOLDEN KING

Period:	7,220 BR - Year Two
Location:	Valea
POV Focus:	Solis, Esterica
KEY CHARACTERS:	Solis - marries Esterica; sends wedding invitation to Orcus as a provocation; receives nickname "the Golden King" from the people of Valea Esterica - becomes queen/empress
MAJOR BEATS:	
CHAPTER 26: WHERE OUR HEARTS GO	

Period:	7,220 BR - Year Two
Period:	7,220 BR - Year Two

Location: Capital city (Orcus's court), the Cidet
POV Focus: Harnua, Orcus

KEY CHARACTERS:

Harnua - offers to marry Orcus (to grant him church protection); rejected; secretly kills higher Cidet members who insulted Orcus

Orcus - rejects Harnua's marriage proposal; doesn't want to look weak

MAJOR BEATS:

- Harnua offers her hand in marriage to Orcus - would grant him the protection of the church
- Orcus rejects her - doesn't want to appear weak
- HARNUA'S FIRST KILLS: Secretly murders higher Cidet members who insulted Orcus
- This is the first time Harnua kills for Orcus

SEEDS PLANTED:

→ Harnua killing for Orcus escalates from here - each kill comes easier

CHAPTER 27: SORORAL

Period: 7,220 BR - Year Two
Location: [TBD - tea party location]
POV Focus: Esterica, Harnua

KEY CHARACTERS:

Esterica - meets Harnua; drops handkerchief on the floor, makes Harnua pick it up; "Your horse will get tired soon."

Harnua - "You haven't won yet."

MAJOR BEATS:

- THE FAMOUS TEA PARTY SCENE
- First Esterica-Harnua meeting since the war started
- Esterica drops her handkerchief and makes Harnua pick it up (power play)
- Harnua: "You haven't won yet."
- Esterica: "Your horse will get tired soon."

QUOTE BANK: Both quotes formatted for hub.

CHAPTER 28: THE THINGS WE LOVE MOST

Period:	7,220 BR - Year Two ends
Location:	Solis's camp, Nyeo
POV Focus:	Esterica, Mihel, Harnua

KEY CHARACTERS:

Esterica - reveals to Mihel that Harnua may love Orcus Mihel - shrugs it off; accidentally tells Harnua about the plan to attack Nyeo; LOSES HIS LEG in resulting counterattack

Harnua - informs Orcus of the Nyeo attack plan; BETRAYS HER BROTHER

MAJOR BEATS:

- Esterica tells Mihel their sister Harnua might love Orcus - Mihel dismisses it
- Mihel accidentally reveals the plan to attack Nyeo to Harnua
- HARNUA BETRAYS MIHEL: Informs Orcus of the attack
- Orcus launches counterattack
- MIHEL LOSES HIS LEG

YEAR TWO SUMMARY:

Solis: Marries Esterica, captures Valea, earns "Golden King" title. Ascending.

Orcus: Massacres Bareta, rejects Harnua's marriage, wins at Nyeo via Harnua's intel.

Mihel: Loses eye (Ch 23) AND leg (Ch 28) in the same year. Devastating.

Harnua: First kills for Orcus; betrays her own brother.

The slide has begun.

Esterica: Now queen; tea party establishes her as a political player.

ARC V: YEAR THREE - BROKEN OATHS

Chapters 29-42 | 7,219 BR

Focus: The war expands internationally. Harnua moves into Orcus's court, sexual entanglements deepen, Jaifey Yuera enters as a new power player, and Iris loses Yera. The longest arc - 14 chapters.

Period:

Location:

POV Focus:

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - attacks the Cidet because Mihel is in a coma

Orcus - rescues Harnua from the temple; offers to house her in his castle

Harnua - rescued by Orcus; moves into his court

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis attacks the Cidet (Harnua's temple) - motivated by rage over Mihel's coma from the Nyeo ambush

- This is a religiously controversial move - attacking sacred ground

- THE CHURCH OFFICIALLY TURNS AGAINST SOLIS

- Orcus rescues Harnua and offers her a place in his castle

CHAPTER 30: DUPLICITY

| Period: | 7,219 BR - Year Three |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Orcus's court |
| POV Focus: | Harnua |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Harnua - struggles in Orcus's court; loyalty questioned;
offers to bring Orcus Mihel's head to prove herself

MAJOR BEATS:

- Harnua adjusting to Orcus's court - everyone questions her loyalties
- To prove herself, she offers to bring Orcus the head of her brother Mihel (whom she believes is defenseless on his deathbed)

CHAPTER 31: BROKEN OATHS

Period: 7,219 BR - Year Three

Location: Gherci, Aicruae

POV Focus: Orcus, Gherci

KEY CHARACTERS:

Orcus - breaks the Treaty of Deouilu; attacks Gherci

Gherci - fires back; declares the Cidet "no longer a place of God" - the evil being Harnua

MAJOR BEATS:

- ORCUS BREAKS THE TREATY OF DEOUILU
- Treaty existed because of Gherci's loyalty to the church - Solis's attack on the Cidet triggered this
- Orcus starts attacking Gherci for supporting Solis
- Gherci responds: Cidet is no longer holy; Harnua is the "evil" that has taken over

CHAPTER 32: THE UNRAVELING

| Period: |

| :— |

| Location: |

| POV Focus: Iris |

| KEY CHARACTERS: |

| Iris - returns home with Yera, who is now pregnant |
| Yera - approximately one month pregnant with "Iris's" child |

MAJOR BEATS:

- Iris returns with Yera - now about a month pregnant
- Iris tells everyone (including Orcus) that the gods blessed them with a child
- TRUTH: Iris forced a slave who resembled her to impregnate Yera, then killed him

CHAPTER 33: WHAT HAS BEEN DONE CANNOT BE UNDONE

| Period: | 7,219 BR - Year Three |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Valea (Mihel's sickbed), Orcus's court |

| POV Focus: | Harnua, Orcus |

| KEY CHARACTERS: | |

| Harnua - sneaks into Valea; almost kills Mihel by suffocating him with a pillow; interrupted by Esterica and Solis; returns to Orcus disappointed | |

| | Orcus - confronts Harnua; their interaction becomes passionate; TAKES HER VIRGINITY by ripping off her chastity belt; pulls out before climaxing |

| Solis - accompanies Esterica | Esterica - bursts through door, saves Mihel |

MAJOR BEATS:

- HARNUA'S ASSASSINATION ATTEMPT ON MIHEL: Sneaks into Valea with Orcus's guards; tries to suffocate Mihel with a pillow
- Esterica and Solis burst in; Harnua forced to abandon the attempt
- Returns to Orcus disappointed
- ORCUS AND HARNUA'S FIRST SEXUAL ENCOUNTER: Orcus confronts her; passion escalates; he rips off her chastity belt; they have sex; he pulls out (fears impregnating her)
- Harnua left "even more disappointed but also more obsessed"

CONTENT NOTE:

The chastity belt detail ties to sainthood restrictions. Harnua losing her virginity to Orcus violates her saintly obligations - she's choosing Orcus over her divine duty. This is the point of no return for her spiritual identity.

CHAPTER 34: THE HAND THAT IS DEALT

| Period: Location: POV Focus: | 7,219 BR - Year Three Valea, Gherci Mihel |
| :— | :— |

| | KEY CHARACTERS: Mihel - wakes from coma; lost eye AND leg; gives up generalship; pivots to tactical/logistical role; sends help to Gherci |

| MAJOR BEATS:

- Mihel wakes from his coma
- Has lost his eye (Ch 23) and his leg (Ch 28) - forced to give up the title of general
- Pivots to “the more tactile side of the war”
- Sends aid to Gherci | |

| CHAPTER 35: RUMOR | |

| Period: Location: POV Focus: | 7,219 BR - Year Three

Solis’s court Solis, Esterica |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - learns of potential Orcus-Harnua alliance;
worried about the political implications
Esterica - devises a plan to spread a rumor that Orcus
defiled Harnua before their wedding night (which turns
out to be true)

MAJOR BEATS :

- Solis hears Orcus and Harnua may form an alliance (marriage would grant Orcus the favor of the gods)
- This threatens Solis’s claim
- ESTERICA’S COUNTER-MOVE: Spreads a rumor that Orcus defiled Harnua before a formal wedding
- The rumor is actually true (Ch 33)

CHAPTER 36: CORRUPTION

| Period: | 7,219 BR - Year Three |
| :— | :— |

| Location: | Solis's camp |
| POV Focus: | Mihel, Solis |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Mihel - strategy with Gherci works

Solis - receives 60,000 Gherci soldiers; deals with their deeply religious faith causing friction

MAJOR BEATS :

- Mihel's strategy pays off - Gherci sends 60,000 men to Solis's army as thanks
- BUT: The Gherci soldiers are deeply religious, which creates problems within Solis's ranks

CHAPTER 37: TO HAVE NOTHING

Period:	7,219 BR - Year Three
:—	:—
Location:	Solis's camp
POV Focus:	Solis, Mihel

KEY CHARACTERS:

Jaifey Yuera - first appearance; Gherci soldier;
military genius whose knowledge surpasses even Solis's
Solis - bonds with Jaifey; they train together
Mihel - begins to feel displaced

MAJOR BEATS:

- JAIFEY YUERA ENTERS THE STORY
- Solis befriends Jaifey - a Gherci military genius whose knowledge even surpasses Solis's
- They train and strategize together
- Mihel begins to question his new position now that he's no longer a general and Jaifey is rising

SEEDS PLANTED:

- Jaifey as Mihel's replacement/rival (payoff: Ch 38-50)
- Jaifey's ambition (payoff: Tixsei, the succession crisis)

CHAPTER 38: MADNESS

Period: 7,219 BR - Year Three
 Location: Solis's court
 POV Focus: Jaifey, Esterica, Mihel

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - appoints Jaifey as new general of second army
 Jaifey - promoted; presents his daughter Tixsei as potential lady-in-waiting for Esterica
 Tixsei Yuera - first appearance; introduced to Esterica
 Esterica & Mihel - trying to decipher Jaifey's true intentions

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis appoints Jaifey as new general of the second army
- Jaifey's ambition revealed: presents his daughter Tixsei as a potential lady-in-waiting to Esterica
- Esterica and Mihel try to figure out what Jaifey is really after

CHAPTER 39: SHIFTING OF THE TIDES

Period:	7,219 BR - Year Three
:—	:—
Location:	Nyeo (recaptured)
POV Focus:	Jaifey, Solis

KEY CHARACTERS:

Jaifey - successfully recaptures Nyeo; people compare him to Mihel; promoted again
 Tixsei - growing closer to Solis

MAJOR BEATS:

- Jaifey leads campaign to recapture Nyeo - succeeds
- People begin comparing Jaifey to Mihel
- Solis grants Jaifey another promotion
- Tixsei and Solis appear to be growing closer

CHAPTER 40: DEVOTION

Period:	7,219 BR - Year Three
:—	:—
Location:	Capital city (Orcus's court)
POV Focus:	Iris, Harnua, Orcus

KEY CHARACTERS:

Iris - prepares for child's birth; growing closer to Yera Orcus - limits meetings with Harnua (rumors circulating)

Harnua - hosts tea party for Iris and Yera; questions Yera's status as Iris's "wife"

Iris - nearly kills Harnua for the comment about Yera

MAJOR BEATS:

- Iris preparing for the birth; she and Yera growing closer
- Orcus pulling away from Harnua because of rumors
- Harnua hosts tea party for Iris and Yera - makes the mistake of questioning Yera's status
- Iris nearly kills Harnua; warns her to watch her tongue

CHAPTER 41: PREMONITION

Period:	7,219 BR - Year Three
:—	:—
Location:	Farm village outside Valea
POV Focus:	Solis, Esterica

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - reassures Esterica he will never marry another Esterica - steals food off his plate; drinks his wine; says it's "too bitter"

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis and Esterica escape to a farm village outside Valea for time together

- Solis promises he will never marry another woman even if Esterica dies
- Esterica steals food off his plate and drinks his wine
- She remarks the wine is "too bitter"

FORESHADOWING:

T Solis's promise to never remarry (payoff: he DOES marry Tixsei after Esterica's death - breaking the promise)
 -> Esterica drinking from his cup (payoff: she drinks the poisoned cup meant for Solis, Ch 68)
 -> "Too bitter" - prefigures the poison

CHAPTER 42: SACRIFICE

Period: 7,219 BR - Year Three ends
 Location: Capital city (Orcus's territory)
 POV Focus: Iris
 KEY CHARACTERS:
 Iris - forced away on a mission; returns to find Yera and child both dead; breakdown
 Yera - dies in childbirth; was in labor for 3 days; baby was stillborn; she was too exhausted to survive

MAJOR BEATS:

- Yera goes into labor; Iris is forced away on a mission to reclaim a stronghold
- The mission fails
- Iris returns to find YERA AND THE CHILD BOTH DEAD
- Baby was stillborn after 3 days of labor; Yera died of exhaustion
- IRIS'S BREAKDOWN: Screaming, crying, hitting herself against the wall; curls up next to Yera's body; kisses Yera's lips; rubs her stomach
- THIS IS THE SECOND TIME WE SEE IRIS CRY
- Iris swears revenge for all the people Solis has caused her to lose

YEAR THREE SUMMARY:

Solis: Attacked the Cidet (controversial), gained 60,000 Gherci troops, Jaifey enters his orbit, Tixsei introduced. Promising Esterica forever.

Orcus: Broke Treaty of Deouilu, housing Harnua, sexual relationship with her begun.

Iris: Pregnant Yera → lost both Yera and child → broken.

Mihel: Woke from coma, pivoted to logistics, being displaced by Jaifey.

Harnua: Tried to kill Mihel, lost virginity to Orcus, entangled with Iris sexually, deepening descent.

Esterica: Political player (rumor campaign), but starting to feel threatened by Tixsei.

ARC VI: YEAR FOUR - THE FIGHT OF BLOOD

Chapters 43-53 | 7,218 BR

Focus: Maen's birth, Iris's revenge campaign, the assassination of Princess Kamerida, internal court politics (Jaifey vs Mihel), and Iris's death.

CHAPTER 43: A KING'S RANSOM [REVISITED]

| Period: |

| :— |

| Location: |

| POV Focus: |

| KEY CHARACTERS: |

| Esterica - gives birth to Solis's first son (MAEN) |

| Iris - sends the head of a baby bear to Solis as a threat against Maen (callback to Ch 2 - bear) |

| Solis - forces Esterica to leave Valea secretly; arranges an impostor to replace her |

MAJOR BEATS :

- PRINCE MAEN IS BORN
- Iris sends a baby bear's head to Solis - warning she will kill his son

- The bear callback: Ch 2 she brought a bear head to his birthday; now she's threatening his child with one
- Solis arranges for Esterica and Maen to leave Valea secretly; an impostor replaces Esterica

CHAPTER 44: STROKING THE FIRE

| Period: | 7,218 BR - Year Four |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Road to/from Valea |

| POV Focus: | Iris, Solis |

| KEY CHARACTERS: | |

| | Iris - ambushes the carriage; decapitates the fake Esterica; discovers the deception; kills a man and stuffs bodies inside a bear she kills |

| MAJOR BEATS: | |

- Iris ambushes carriage she believes carries Esterica
- Personally decapitates the impostor
- Searches for Maen - he's not there
- Discovers it was a fake
- In rage: kills a man, stuffs bodies inside a dead bear, sends it back to Solis
- Solis's men attempt to detain Iris - she escapes

CHAPTER 45: THOSE WE LEAVE BEHIND

Period: 7,218 BR - Year Four

Location: Capital city, Yera's grave

POV Focus: Iris, Orcus

KEY CHARACTERS:

Iris - returns to capital covered in blood, unbathed

Orcus - observes but doesn't intervene; recognizes her grief

Iris - gets drunk; visits Yera's grave; pours wine; cries; says she's sorry

MAJOR BEATS:

- Iris returns to capital still covered in blood
- Orcus watches; doesn't intervene; understands this is how she grieves
- Iris gets drunk
- Visits Yera's grave; pours wine over it; cries; apologizes

CHAPTER 46: LIKE A MOTH TO A FLAME

| Period: | 7,218 BR - Year Four |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Capital city |

| POV Focus: | Harnua, Iris |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Harnua & Iris - grow closer; become sexually involved
Iris - aware Harnua is using her because Harnua sees Orcus's resemblance in her

MAJOR BEATS:

- Harnua and Iris grow closer as Iris processes Yera's death
- They become sexually involved on multiple occasions
- Iris knows Harnua is only using her - sees Orcus in

Iris because they're twins

- Iris accepts this anyway

CHAPTER 47: THE RED WOMAN

Period:	7,218 BR - Year Four
Location:	Valea
POV Focus:	Esterica, Mihel

KEY CHARACTERS:

Esterica - returns to Valea; distraught to find Tixsei and Solis have grown closer

Mihel - reveals Jaifey has nearly taken over his position in Solis's council

MAJOR BEATS:

- Esterica returns to Valea after the impostor scheme
- Discovers Tixsei and Solis have grown closer in her absence
- Mihel reveals Jaifey Yuera has almost completely taken over his position in Solis's council

CHAPTER 48: DAMAGE DONE

Period:	7,218 BR - Year Four
Location:	Solis's court
POV Focus:	Mihel, Jaifey

KEY CHARACTERS:

Mihel - scrambling to recover his influence; fears for Maen's future if he fails

Jaifey - actively dividing the court; influencing

Solis's mental state (unbeknownst to Solis)

MAJOR BEATS :

- Mihel and Jaifey in open power struggle
- Both trying to control Solis's decisions and mental state - Solis doesn't realize the court is splitting
- Mihel fears what happens to Maen if Jaifey wins

CHAPTER 49: THE HAND THAT IS DEALT (REVISITED)

| Period: | 7,218 BR - Year Four |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Northern Aicruae |

POV Focus: Solis, Mihel, Jaifey

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - ambushed in northern Aicruae; co-general Vinala dies securing his escape; retreats; slaps Mihel in front of court

Mihel - insisted Solis go; banished after the ambush

Jaifey - warned Solis it was a trap (proved right)

Vinala - dies; Solis cannot recover the body

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis ventures north after reports Iris is disrupting trade routes
- Jaifey warns it could be a trap

- Mihel insists: if Solis lets Iris scare him, he's no king
- SOLIS IS AMBUSHED
- Co-general Vinala dies securing Solis's escape
- Solis cannot recover Vinala's body
- Returns to Valea; SLAPS MIHEL in front of the entire court
- MIHEL BANISHED until mourning period for Vinala ends

CHAPTER 50: A DEBT OWED

| Period: | 7,218 BR - Year Four |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Valea (Solis's court) |

| POV Focus: | Solis, Esterica, Jaifey |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - receives prophetic dream from Nimlye showing history repeating; immediately declares Maen as heir

Esterica - argues with Solis about Mihel's banishment; relieved when Maen is named heir

Jaifey - infuriated by Maen's naming (was planning to produce an heir between Solis and Tixsei)

Nimlye - Goddess of Secrets and Fate; sends the dream

MAJOR BEATS:

- Esterica and Solis argue about Mihel's treatment
- NIMLYE'S DREAM: Solis receives a disturbing prophetic dream - history repeating; Esterica losing favor; two sons fighting for the throne (like him and Orcus)
- Terrified, Solis immediately declares MAEN AS HIS HEIR
- Written into his will; made a public announcement
- Jaifey is furious - his plan was to produce a Solis-

Tixsei heir

- Esterica comforted - she'd begun fearing for her

SEEDS PLANTED:

- Nimlye's involvement (the dream comes true in a sense: Maen does inherit, but produces no heirs; the cycle continues differently than expected)
- Jaifey's thwarted ambition (payoff: Tixsei still becomes second wife after Esterica's death)

CHAPTER 51: RUMOR [SECOND USE OF TITLE]

Period:	7,218 BR - Year Four
:—	:—
Location:	At sea (Gherci waters), Aicruae
POV Focus:	Iris, Harnua

KEY CHARACTERS:

Iris - leads the assassination of Princess Kamerida

Harnua - co-conspirator in the assassination

Princess Kamerida Mava of Gherci - killed along with 10 high-ranking ladies-in-waiting

MAJOR BEATS:

- Iris learns the ambush on Solis failed
- Iris and Harnua plot to assassinate Princess Kamerida of Gherci (sent as envoy to discuss strategy with Solis)
- They attack the Gherci ships
- PRINCESS KAMERIDA ASSASSINATED along with 10 of her high-ranking ladies-in-waiting

CHAPTER 52: MOVES AND COUNTERMOVES

Period: 7,218 BR - Year Four

Location: Capital city (Orcus's court)

POV Focus: Orcus, Iris, Harnua

KEY CHARACTERS:

Orcus - discovers Iris-Harnua conspiracy; punishes Iris publicly for the first time; shocked by their

relationship

Iris - defends herself; claims she did what was needed to protect her king

Harnua - defends Iris; Orcus learns the true nature of

their relationship

Gherci - sends soldiers to fight Orcus directly

MAJOR BEATS:

- Orcus discovers Iris and Harnua conspired to kill Kamerida
- FOR THE FIRST TIME, ORCUS PUBLICLY DISAGREES WITH AND PUNISHES IRIS
- Iris defends herself: "I did what I saw fit to protect my brother and my king"
- Harnua defends Iris - revealing their relationship to Orcus
- Orcus's court is in chaos; clearly unstable
- Gherci sends soldiers; begins pushing back against Orcus's forces
- THIS MARKS THE END OF YEAR FOUR AND THE START OF "THE FIGHT OF BLOOD"

CHAPTER 53: THE GEM OF THE PEOPLE'S EYE

Period: 7,218 BR - Year Four ends

Location: Rewqo (city outside Lajazer)

POV Focus: Solis, Iris

KEY CHARACTERS:

Iris - faces Solis in battle; captured; attempts to escape; killed by Solis after killing 15 men

Solis - kills Iris; grieves; buries her beneath a temple of Nellebrie

MAJOR BEATS:

- IRIS DIES AT THE BATTLE OF REWQO
- Iris and Solis face off in battle

- Iris is captured
- She attempts to escape - in the struggle, she is killed by Solis
- (From other sources: she kills 15 men before dying)
- Solis grieves - despite everything, she was family
- Solis buries Iris beneath a temple of Nellebrie at Rewqo; prays she finds peace

YEAR FOUR SUMMARY:

Solis: Maen born, Maen named heir, court splitting (Jaifey vs Mihel), ambushed in north, kills Iris.

Orcus: Court collapsing; punished Iris publicly for first time; lost international credibility.

Iris: DIES. Bear revenge campaign, Yera grief, Kamerida assassination, killed at Rewqo.
 Harnua: Co-conspirator in Kamerida assassination; sexually involved with both Orcus and Iris.
 Mihel: Banished temporarily; displaced by Jaifey.
 Esterica: Threatened by Tixsei; relieved when Maen named heir.

ARC VII: YEAR FIVE - THE FALL

Chapters 54-65 | 7,217 BR

Focus: The war's bloodiest year. Sevtor's magical attack, the destruction of House Orana, Duke Reasaec's execution, Esterica's stillborn, the emotional reckoning, and Orcus's death.

CHAPTER 54: WOE UNTO HE

| Period: | 7,217 BR - Year Five begins |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Capital city (Orcus's court) |

| POV Focus: | Orcus, Harnua |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Orcus - learns of Iris's death; guilt-stricken (last memory of her is anger); depressed; court crumbling
 Harnua - also learns of Iris's death

MAJOR BEATS:

- Orcus and Harnua learn Iris is dead
- Orcus consumed by guilt - last memory of Iris is their fight (Ch 52)
- Orcus visibly depressed; zoned out in council meetings
- Court members losing faith - they now see Iris was the real power behind Orcus

CHAPTER 55: THE MORNING STORM

| Period: | 7,217 BR - Year Five |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Valea, Aicruae |

| POV Focus: | Solis, Orcus |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Duke Reasaec Kivier - arrives from Equateiy to aid Orcus
Grand Sorcerer Sevtor - arrives from Vikistv with family;
ATTACKS VALEA WITH MAGIC - 15,000 DEAD
Cequailian Orana - Sevtor's second son; betrothed to Iris
Solis, Esterica, Maen - terrified
Mihel - fearful

MAJOR BEATS:

- Duke Reasaec Kivier of Equateiy and Grand Sorcerer Sevtor of Vikistv travel to Aicruae to personally aid Orcus
- Their purpose: to avenge Iris (whom Orcus had betrothed to Sevtor's second son, Cequailian)
- SEVTOR ATTACKS VALEA WITH MAGIC - 15,000 DEAD
- Solis, Esterica, Maen left scared
- Mihel feeling fearful

CHAPTER 56: THE WRATH OF THE GREAT ONES

Period: 7,217 BR - Year Five
Location: [Solis's camp - location TBD]

POV Focus: Solis, Jaifey, Mihel

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - strategizes counter to magic users; orders kidnapping of Maeret Orana; permits experiments despite Maeret's pleas

Jaifey - part of the counter-strategy

Mihel - part of the counter-strategy

Maeret Orana - Sevtor's third son; kidnapped; experimented on; reveals fire weakness

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis, Jaifey, and Mihel plan how to counter the magic users
- They kidnap MAERET ORANA (Sevtor's third son)
- Experiment on him to discover magic user weakness
- Maeret pleads for mercy - says he had no control over his father's actions
- Solis ignores him; permits further experiments
- DISCOVERY: Fire is lethal to these magic users their bodies rely on cold and cannot handle high temperatures

<u>3</u>	Period:
Location:	House Orana's castle, Aicruae
POV Focus:	Solis, Esterica

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - orders House Orana burned alive using Liacaion; the screams echo throughout Aicruae

Esterica - begins flinching at Solis's touch; they stop sleeping in the same bed

Mekean Orana - escapes by dyeing her hair; settles in Equateiy (ancestor of Merigen Bleelack)

MAJOR BEATS :

- THIS CHAPTER "HINTS AT SOLIS'S DARKER SIDE AND WHAT HE WILL EVENTUALLY BECOME - A MONSTER BENT ON REVENGE"
- Solis sends a spy to infiltrate House Orana's castle
- Spy pours LIACAION (gasoline) into their chambers
- Spy lights the fire
- ALL MEMBERS OF HOUSE ORANA BURN TO DEATH

- (Unknown: Mekean escapes by dyeing her hair; settles in Equateiy; continues the bloodline → Merigen Bleelack)
- The screams echo throughout Aicruae that night
- Solis and Esterica no longer sleep in the same bed
- ESTERICA BEGINS TO FLINCH EVERY TIME SOLIS TOUCHES HER

TURNING POINT:

This is the chapter where Solis crosses the line from justified avenger to war criminal. Esterica's physical recoil is the reader's moral compass reacting.

CHAPTER 58: BLOOD REAPS BLOOD

| Period: | 7,217 BR - Year Five |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Quather Sea, Gherci |

| POV Focus: | Solis, Jaifey |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - personally attacks Duke Reasaec's fleeing ship;
takes his head; sends it to Gherci with a note

Jaifey - urges Solis to deal with the fleeing men

Duke Reasaec Kivier - BEHEADED AT SEA

King of Gherci - preserves Reasaec's head; forces mouth
open; hangs it at castle entrance

MAJOR BEATS :

- Duke Reasaec attempting to flee back to Equateiy by ship; members of Orcus's court also escaping
- Jaifey urges Solis to act to restore Gherci's favor
- Solis PERSONALLY attacks the ship with his first army
- Takes Reasaec's head
- Sends it to Gherci with a note in Ananara: "The head of a rat - do as you please with it."

- King of Gherci preserves the head, forces the mouth open, hangs it at the castle entrance

CHAPTER 59: THE PRICE OF WAR

| Period: | 7,217 BR - Year Five |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Valea (or current base) |

| POV Focus: | Solis, Esterica |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Esterica - gives birth to second child; BABY IS STILLBORN; experiencing disturbing dreams about Tixsei and Solis

Solis - struggling to cope with loss

Tixsei - offers to serve as Esterica's lady-in-waiting

MAJOR BEATS:

- Esterica gives birth to Solis's second child - a son
- THE BABY IS STILLBORN
- Solis and Esterica struggle to cope; the war is driving a wedge between them
- Esterica has disturbing dreams of Tixsei and Solis together, with Tixsei birthing Solis's children
- Esterica struggling to maintain her image as queen
- Tixsei offers to serve as her lady-in-waiting

CHAPTER 60: WARMEST EMBRACE

| Period: | 7,217 BR - Year Five |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | [Solis and Esterica's quarters] |

| POV Focus: | Solis, Esterica |

| KEY CHARACTERS: | |

| | Solis - attempts to reconnect with Esterica; weeps on her shoulder; approximately 4,000 words of dialogue |

| | Esterica - emotional support |

| MAJOR BEATS: | |

- Solis tries to reconnect with Esterica

- Explains why events have unfolded as they have
- EXTENDED EMOTIONAL CONVERSATION (~ 4,000 words of dialogue)
- Solis weeps on Esterica's shoulder
- They discuss fears, problems, and hopes for the future

CRAFT NOTE:

This is the emotional climax of the Solis-Esterica relationship. At ~ 4,000 words of dialogue, it's the longest conversation in the book. Consider: this is the last real moment of connection before everything breaks apart.

CHAPTER 61: INNOCENCE LONG GONE

Period:	7,217 BR - Year Five
:—	:—
Location:	Aicruae - march toward Lajazer
POV Focus:	Solis

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - marches on the capital; reminisces about what Aicruae used to be

Orcus - barricaded inside the castle; reportedly as mad as his mother once was

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis learns Orcus has barricaded himself in the castle
- Orcus reportedly "as mad as his mother once was"
- Solis's first army sets out for the capital
- As they pass through Aicruae, Solis reminisces about the city's former self
- He longs for a moment of time travel back to what it was

CHAPTER 62: THE FIGHT OF TITIAN

Period: 7,217 BR - Year Five

Location: Outside Lajazer

POV Focus: Solis

KEY CHARACTERS:

Dame Kisaleli - fearsome warrior trained by Ser Wanez
 since age 2; kills 700 of Solis's men before dying;

last words: "Glory to Orcus, the one true king"
Solis - only wins when Razar blinds Kisaleli; stabs

her in the chest; slits her throat
Razar - DIVINE INTERVENTION: blinds Dame Kisaleli
Ser Wanez - mentioned as Kisaleli's trainer

MAJOR BEATS:

- THE FIGHT OF TITIAN
- Solis's first and second armies confront Dame Kisaleli
- Dame Kisaleli was trained by Ser Wanez since age 2
- She kills 700 OF SOLIS'S MEN before falling
- The battle only turns when RAZAR BLINDS KISALELI momentarily
- Solis slips through and stabs her in the chest
- KISALELI'S LAST WORDS: "Glory to Orcus, the one true king."
- Solis slits her throat

CHAPTER 63: ONE-ON-ONE

Period: 7,217 BR - Year Five
Location: Lajazer - outside and inside the capital
POV Focus: Solis
KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - fights through to the capital
Ser Taryria - "I am no rat; do not think me such a
fool - I will die defending my king." DIES.
Lady Olia - battles her own mother; DIES.
Dame Exara - battles her own daughter (Lady Olia);
"I am a terrible mother for I shall wear my child's
blood as victory and with honor." Refuses to recover
Olia's body; labels her a traitor.

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis confronts Orcus's army head-on at the capital
- Solis vs Ser Taryria: Taryria's defiant declaration of loyalty to Orcus
- Lady Olia vs Dame Exara: MOTHER vs DAUGHTER
- Exara's devastating line about wearing her child's blood as victory
- Ser Taryria and Lady Olia both die

- Dame Exara shows no remorse; refuses to recover her daughter's body; calls her a traitor to the gods

<u>4</u>	Period:
Location:	Lajazer - Royal Castle Throne Room
POV Focus:	Solis, Orcus

KEY CHARACTERS:

Orcus - cornered in the throne room; duels Solis; refuses banishment; STABS HIMSELF IN THE CHEST

Solis - wins the duel but does not kill Orcus; offers banishment; watches his brother choose death

MAJOR BEATS:

- ORCUS DIES IN THE THRONE ROOM
- Solis corners Orcus against a wall; forces a head-on duel
- During the duel, their conversation reveals how much Solis loved his brother and how their father turned them against each other
- Solis wins but DOES NOT KILL ORCUS
- Points his sword at Orcus's chest; asks him to surrender and be banished
- ORCUS'S DEATH SPEECH: "You have always bested me, brother - with arrows and with swords, with hair and with status. I refuse to live in a world where I must be reminded time and time again of my failure..."
- Orcus declares he would rather join his sister than live in this world
- ORCUS STABS HIMSELF and bleeds to death

CHAPTER 65: THE FUNERAL

Period:	7,217 BR - Year Five ends
:—	:—
Location:	Rewqo (burial site - same as Iris)
POV Focus:	Solis

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - buries Orcus beside Iris; cries heavily; does not sleep for 10 nights;

wonders if things could have been different

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis holds a funeral for Orcus
- Buries him beside Iris at Rewqo
- Solis cries heavily throughout the funeral
- DOES NOT SLEEP FOR 10 NIGHTS
- Mourns his brother; wonders if things could have been different for all three of them
- THE CIVIL WAR ENDS

YEAR FIVE SUMMARY:

Solis: Sevtor's attack, House Orana destroyed, Reasaec beheaded, stillborn son, emotional reckoning with Esterica, divine intervention at Titian, Orcus's death. The war is won but at immense cost.

Orcus: Barricaded, mad, defeated, chooses suicide over banishment.

Esterica: Stillborn, flinching from Solis, dreams of Tixsei replacing her.

Mihel: Part of the counter-magic strategy.

Harnua: Offscreen during Year Five battles - returns for revenge arc.

EPILOGUE ARC: CONQUEST & AFTERMATH

Chapters 66-70 | 7,215 BR - 7,163 BR | Post-War

Focus: The aftermath. Esterica's death, Harnua's revenge, Solis's conquest, and the fates of all characters.

CHAPTER 66: LEGACY

Period: ~7,215 BR (2 years into Solis's rule)

Location: [Capital / imperial court]

POV Focus: Solis, Esterica

KEY CHARACTERS:

Esterica - gives birth to daughter COYRE

Solis - ruling

Coyre - nicknamed "the light of the kingdom" for her beauty and Patton traits

MAJOR BEATS:

- Two years into Solis's rule
- Esterica gives birth to PRINCESS COYRE
- Coyre nicknamed "the light of the kingdom"

CHAPTER 67: SEEKING REVENGE

| Period: | ~ 7,214 BR |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | Lajazer (capital), Vikistv |

POV Focus: Harnua

KEY CHARACTERS:

Harnua - sneaks back into the capital; watches Solis and Esterica from a distance; travels between Vikistv and Aicruae searching for Fazen (fast-acting poison)

MAJOR BEATS:

- Harnua sneaks back into the capital
- Begins planning her revenge against Solis and Esterica
- Watches them from a distance
- Travels between Vikistv and Aicruae searching for FAZEN - a lethal poison that kills in seconds and leaves virtually no trace

NOTE: This chapter uses Fazen, not Ilkai. The Ilkai (god-killing herb) comes from the Nellebrie deal. Confirm: does Harnua initially pursue Fazen and then switch to Ilkai when she realizes she needs divine-level power to bypass Razar's protection? Or is this an inconsistency to resolve?

CHAPTER 68: THE FLOWER THAT BLOOMS [SECOND USE OF TITLE]

| Period: |

| :— |

| Location: |

| POV Focus: |

| KEY CHARACTERS: |

| Harnua - disguises herself as wine bearer; poisons |

| Solis's cup with Ilkai; Esterica drinks instead; |

| CAPTURED; BURNED AT THE STAKE; raises second moon |

| Esterica - DIES from the poison (drinks the cup meant for Solis) |
| Solis - asks Razar who is responsible; told it was Harnua; captures and executes her; grief-maddened |
| Razar - identifies Harnua as the assassin |
| Nellebrie - provided Harnua with Ilkai and the power to bypass Razar's protection |
| Coyre - recently born (approximately 6 months old) |
| Tixsei - Solis leans on her for support raising Coyre; eventually takes her as queen |

MAJOR BEATS:

- Shortly after Coyre's birth
- Harnua disguises herself as a wine bearer at a celebration of Solis's reign
- Pours Ilkai into Solis's wine cup
- ESTERICA ACCIDENTALLY DRINKS THE POISONED CUP
- Esterica dies instantly
- Solis asks Razar who is responsible - Razar tells him it was Harnua
- Solis captures Harnua
- HARNUA BURNED AT THE STAKE
- With her dying breath, Harnua RAISES A SECOND MOON in honor of Orcus
- Orcus's moon: bigger than Solis's moon, spins 3x faster, always beating Solis's in rotation
- Harnua's death (as 13th Saint) creates the 13th month: AGARISONO (40 days)
- BOTH HARNUA AND ESTERICA DIE IN THIS CHAPTER
- Solis left with infant Coyre; doesn't know how to raise a girl
- Leans on Tixsei; eventually takes her as his queen (despite not loving her - breaks Ch 41 promise)

CALLBACK: Esterica drinking from Solis's cup mirrors Ch 41 where she steals food off his plate and drinks his wine, calling it "too bitter." The foreshadowing pays off here with devastating precision.

CHAPTER 69: CONQUEST AND CLEANSING

| Period: | 7, 214BR – 7, 163BR (Solis's remaining reign) |

| :— | :— |

| Location: | All six kingdoms |

| POV Focus: | Solis |

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - conquers remaining kingdoms; systematically persecutes magic users; becomes the emperor

MAJOR BEATS:

- Solis embarks on conquering the remaining kingdoms
- Systematically killing/persecuting magic users (motivated by fear of another Harnua)
- Covers Solis's life trajectory after Esterica's death
- His transformation from grieving widower to empire-building tyrant is complete

CHAPTER 70: EPILOGUE

Period: 7,163 BR - 7,140 BR (deaths of Solis and Maen)

Location: The empire

POV Focus: Omniscient / Summary

KEY CHARACTERS:

Solis - dies at 87; ruled for 53 years; four children

Esterica - legacy: agricultural reforms, two libraries, "Mother of a Dynasty"

Mihel - made Duke; leaves for Mystic Isles; swears off women; ends his family line

Maen - inherits throne; renames empire "Solisian Empire"; three wives, no heirs; dies 7,140 BR

Coyre - builds a museum in Esterica's honor; her eldest son (Emperor Elleinaj I) inherits after Maen

Tixsei - Solis's second wife; children Snieoa and Bier

Harnua - legacy: second moon, 13th month, end of saints

MAJOR BEATS:

- Epilogue sums up the fates of ALL characters
- Details their deaths and lives after the war
- Who followed Solis; whom he married after Esterica; what he accomplished
- Solis dies at 87 (7,163 BR); four children total: Maen, Coyre (by Esterica), Snieoa, Bier (by Tixsei)
- Maen renames the empire the SOLISIAN EMPIRE
- Maen dies 7,140 BR with no heirs; throne passes to Coyre's son Elleinaj I

- Mihel: Duke → retires to Mystic Isles; ends his line
- Solis is remembered as "the king of light and bringer of the new age" - but the narrative frames him as the villain whose conquest ushered in humanity's fall

APPENDIX A: CHAPTER-TO-WAR-YEAR QUICK REFERENCE

PRE-WAR (Childhood & Exile)

- Ch 1 7,250 BR Solis born
- Ch 2 7,246 BR Solis turns 4
- Ch 3 7,243 BR Solis turns 7 (Queen Mihai dead)
- Ch 4 7,241 BR Solis turns 9; coup; exile begins
- Ch 5 7,234 BR Solis ~16; Razar pledge; army built
- Ch 6 7,230s BR Mihel discovers Solis's identity
- Ch 7 7,220s BR Solis infiltrates twins' court
- Ch 8 ~2 yrs later Solis returns; knighted; guards Iris

Ch 9 7,221 BR Solis is 29; twins turn 35; the ball

YEAR ONE (7,221 BR)

- Ch 10-21 (12 chapters)
- Key: War begins, Esterica joins, Jasereiey trench warfare, international alliances, Yera enslaved, Year One victory

YEAR TWO (7,220 BR)

- Ch 22-28 (7 chapters)
- Key: Bareta massacre, Valea captured, Solis-Esterica marriage, tea party, Mihel loses eye AND leg, Harnua betrays Mihel

YEAR THREE (7,219 BR)

- Ch 29-42 (14 chapters)
- Key: Cidet attacked, Treaty of Deouilu broken, Harnua-Orcus sexual, Mihel wakes, Jaifey enters, Tixsei introduced, Yera and baby die, foreshadowing Ch 41

YEAR FOUR (7,218 BR)

- Ch 43-53 (11 chapters)
- Key: Maen born, bear threats, Kamerida assassinated, "Fight of Blood" era, IRIS DIES at Rewqo

YEAR FIVE (7,217 BR)

- Ch 54-65 (12 chapters)
- Key: Sevtor's attack, House Orana destroyed, Reasaec beheaded, stillborn, Fight of Titian, Kisaleli/Taryria/Olia/Exara deaths, ORCUS DIES

POST-WAR (7,215 BR - 7,163 BR)

- Ch 66-70 (5 chapters)
- Key: Coyre born, Harnua's revenge, ESTERICA AND HARNUA DIE, conquest, epilogue

APPENDIX B: CHARACTER DEATH TRACKER

Queen Mihai	~ 7, 243 BR	Pre-war	(between Ch 2-3)
:—	:—	:—	:—
King Benjamin II	7,241 BR	Ch 4	Sudden death
Lady Emillea Hige	7,241 BR	Ch 4	Poisoned (coup)
Yera	7,219 BR	Ch 42	Childbirth
Yera's baby	7,219 BR	Ch 42	Stillborn
Iris Patton	7,218 BR	Ch 53	Battle of Rewqo
Sevtor (& House	7,217 BR	Ch 57	Burned alive

Orana, minus Mekean)			(Liacaion)
Duke Reasaec	7, 217BR	Ch 58	Beheaded at sea
Solis's 2nd child	7,217 BR	Ch 59	Stillborn
Dame Kisaleli	7, 217BR	Ch 62	Fight of Titian
Ser Taryria	7,217 BR	Ch 63	Battle at capital
Lady Olia	7, 217BR	Ch 63	Killed by her mother (Exara)
Orcus Patton	7, 217BR	Ch 64	Suicide (throne room)
Esterica Kulio	7,214 BR	Ch 68	Poisoned (Ilkai)
Harnua Kulio	7,214 BR	Ch 68	Burned at stake
Solis Patton	7,163 BR	Ch 70	Natural causes (age 87)
Maen Patton	7,140 BR	Ch 70	Natural causes

APPENDIX C: UNRESOLVED QUESTIONS / CONFIRM

1. THE BLUE TOWER (Ch 2) - Is this a named location within the royal castle?
Needs LOCATIONS entry if so.
2. JONATHAN KIVA vs JANRANO KIVA (Ch 5 vs Ch 6) - Which is canon? Or are both valid (common-tongue vs Ananara)?
3. FAZEN vs ILKAI (Ch 67 vs Ch 68) - Does Harnua initially search for Fazen and then switch to Ilkai after the Nellebrie deal? Or is Ch 67's reference to Fazen an error that should be Ilkai?
4. QUEEN MIHAI'S DEATH DATE - Offscreen between Ch 2 and Ch 3. The twins are 13 and Solis is 7 when she dies (~ 7, 243 BR) . Confirm for HISTORICAL

FIGURES.

5. CHAPTERS 22, 23, 24 - These appear untitled in the chapter breakdown. Confirm whether they have titles or are intentionally untitled.
6. CHAPTER 15 and CHAPTER 68 share the title "THE FLOWER THAT BLOOMS." Chapter 35 and Chapter 51 share the title "RUMOR." Chapter 43 and Chapter 49 share variants of "A KING'S RANSOM" / "THE HAND THAT IS DEALT." Confirm whether these repeated titles are intentional thematic echoes or need differentiation.
7. VINALA (Ch 49) - Solis's co-general who dies. Is this character developed enough elsewhere for an IN STORY CHARACTERS entry, or is this their only appearance?
8. SER WANEZ (Ch 62) - Trained Dame Kisaleli since age 2. Is this character developed elsewhere or is this their only mention?

RELATIONSHIP: ORCUS AND HARNUA

TIMELINE

Age 9: Harnua first fell for Orcus (childhood infatuation). Her mother wanted her to marry Solis, the respectable prince, but Harnua was deeply infatuated with Orcus. Rather than disappoint her mother, Harnua ignored her own feelings.

Age 10: Harnua discovered she was a saint blessed by Nellebrie. She was forced into a life of worship and solitude where she could only see Orcus twice a year - on his birthday and on the anniversary of his mother's death.

War Year Two (~ 7, 220BR): Harnua offered her hand in marriage to Orcus to grant him the protection of the church. He rejected her because he did not want to look weak.

During the War: Harnua secretly killed higher temple members who insulted Orcus - these were her first kills, committed for him. Later, Orcus rescued Harnua from the Cidet when Solis attacked it.

NATURE OF THE RELATIONSHIP

This is an unrequited/one-sided devotion. Harnua loved Orcus deeply and was willing to kill for him. Orcus was emotionally unavailable - he grew up with a complete emotional blockage toward love due to his parents' troubled relationship. He was not cruel to Harnua, but he could not give her what she needed.

CHAPTER 29 - SOLIS ATTACKS THE CIDET

During the war, Solis attacked the Cidet (Chapter 29), violating sacred ground. This act turned the church decisively against him and became one of the defining controversies of his conquest. Post-war, repairing his relationship with the Cidet became a critical political project for Solis and his fledgling empire.
(See also: LOCATIONS - Cidet governance entry)

1. ERA 8: THE AICRUAN CIVIL WAR & SOLIS'S CONQUEST
(~7,260 BR - 7,163 BR) 
2. Event: Civil War Year Two - Marriage of Solis and Esterica Location: Aicruae - Bareta attacked, Valea taken
Key Figures: Solis, Esterica Kulio, Orcus, Harnua, Mihel
Significance: Solis becomes known as "The Golden King" after marrying Esterica Kulio. The Massacre at Bareta (Orcus's stronghold) occurs. Mihel 
3. CHAPTER 57: THE LOST ONE 
4. CHAPTER 64: A BROKEN BOND 

A TALE OF A THOUSAND SONGS Characters

Family Tree

A VISUAL TRAILER FOR A TALE OF A THOUSAND SONGS.